DRAGONLANCE

THE KNIGHT'S OATH

A Choose Your Own Adventure Prelude

Book I of the Shadow of the Dragon Queen Solo Campaign | Version 19

You are a young squire standing at the gates of the Solamnic Orders.
Fighter or Paladin — the choice is yours. Train. Fight. Choose.
At the adventure's end one Order will claim your oath —
Rose, Sword, or Crown — and you will ride to Vogler as their squire.

Levels 1-3 | ~35-40 Hours Solo Play | Version 19 | 110+ Scenes | 3 Possible Orders
Fighter OR Paladin | 5 Combat Encounters | 8 Romance Arcs
Paladin: 4 Divine Quest Scenes | 5 Gods | Chosen or Choosing

HOW TO PLAY THIS BOOK

Welcome, Squire

This is a solo Choose Your Own Adventure set in Krynn during the opening days of the War of the Lance. You play a human Solamnic squire. Your first decision — made at Scene 0 before the story begins — is whether you are a Fighter or a Paladin.

Both paths share the same story, companions, romance arcs, Order choices, and combat encounters. Paladins additionally experience four special divine quest scenes woven throughout the adventure, where the old gods — silent for three hundred years — begin to stir.

Element	How It Works
Scenes	Numbered scenes tell the story. Read fully before choosing.
Choices	Blue boxes = standard choices with Order point awards.
Paladin Scenes	Gold-bordered scenes are Paladin only. Fighters skip to the next scene number.
Order Points	Track ROSE, SWORD, and CROWN points on the tally at back.
God Signs	Paladins track divine signs separately — one tally per god. Most tallies = your deity.
Roll Boxes	Green = required roll. Amber = optional. Roll d20, meet or beat the DC to succeed.
Combat	Orange boxes are fights. Use the provided stat blocks.
Companions	Green banners = NPC joins. Red banners = NPC departs.
Level Ups	Navy boxes mark level gains. Update your character sheet before continuing.
No Dice?	Flip a coin for any roll: Heads = success, Tails = failure.
Death	0 HP in combat: turn to that fight's Fallen entry.
Conviction Tracks	Some companions challenge your beliefs. Track the consequences on the score sheet.
Time	The ~35-40 hour estimate is a suggestion, not a target. Read slowly. Sit with a scene. Re-read a choice. This is your story — take the time it deserves.

The Three Orders

ORDER OF THE ROSE

Justice. Wisdom. Scholars and judges first, warriors second. Earn ROSE by choosing mercy, applying the Measure thoughtfully, protecting the innocent.

ORDER OF THE SWORD

Courage. Valour. Warriors sworn to the gods of good. Earn SWORD by choosing courage over caution, fighting bravely, refusing to flee.

ORDER OF THE CROWN

Law. Order. Duty above self. Earn CROWN by following lawful orders, maintaining discipline, fulfilling duty even at personal cost.

USING YOUR OWN CHARACTER SHEET (CPC)

This prelude works with the Native PC sheet on the next page or your own Created Player Character (CPC). If you are using a CPC: • CPC must be a Level 1 Fighter or Paladin with STR 14+ and CHA 12+. • Wherever native PC stats appear (AC 16, HP 12/10, +5 attack), use your own values. • ADD TO INVENTORY boxes: add the listed item to whichever sheet you are using. • MARK ON YOUR CHARACTER SHEET boxes: permanent change — update your CPC sheet now. • TRACK YOUR HP boxes appear after every combat — update before continuing. • LEVEL UP boxes include both native PC values and CPC-specific instructions. • The native PC stat block is Fighter STR 16, DEX 12, CON 14, INT 10, WIS 12, CHA 14. Paladin: STR 16, DEX 10, CON 13, INT 8, WIS 12, CHA 14.

BEFORE THE STORY BEGINS — CHOOSE YOUR PATH

Before Scene 1, make one choice: are you a Fighter or a Paladin? This shapes how magic, combat, and the divine work in your story. It does not determine your Order — both classes can reach Rose, Sword, or Crown.

Starting Equipment

Item	Notes	Carried
Longsword	1d8+3 slashing, versatile (1d10)	■
Chain Mail Armour	AC 16, no DEX bonus, disadvantage on Stealth	■
Shield	+2 AC when equipped (optional — remove if two-handing)	■
Dagger	1d4+3, finesse, thrown (20/60 ft.)	■
Explorer's Pack	Bedroll, tinderbox, 10 torches, 10 days rations, waterskin, 50 ft. rope	■
Solamnic Tabard	Grants recognition as a Solamnic squire. Social effect.	■
Mira's Travel Bundle	Yarrow, bandages, salve. (Acquired Scene 21 if Mira joins)	△
Baaz Stone Fragment	Trinket. Earned in first combat. No mechanical effect.	△
Patrol Sketch	Intelligence item. +1 Scene 52 if shown to Caeron.	△
Aldous's Compass	Trinket. Points 12° west of north. Bring to main campaign.	△

■ = starting equipment. △ = conditionally acquired during play. CPC users: your starting equipment may differ — use this as a reference guide.

FIGHTER

Level 1: HP 12. Second Wind (1d10+1 HP, bonus action, 1/short rest). Fighting Style (choose one: Dueling, Great Weapon, or Protection).

Level 2: Action Surge (extra action, 1/short rest). Fighter Archetype (Champion, Battle Master, or Eldritch Knight).

Level 3: Full Archetype features active.

Stats: STR 16 (+3), DEX 12 (+1), CON 14 (+2), INT 10, WIS 12 (+1), CHA 10. HP 12. AC 16. Prof +2.

Attack: Longsword +5, 1d8+3. Dagger +5, 1d4+3.

Story: Pure martial path. No divine scenes. Your strength is discipline and steel. The gods are absent — and you make do without them.

PALADIN

Level 1: HP 10. Lay on Hands (5 HP pool/long rest, touch to heal). Divine Sense (detect celestials/undead/fiends within 60 ft., WIS bonus uses/day).

Level 2: Divine Smite (expend a spell slot on hit: +2d8 radiant, +3d8 vs undead/fiends). Fighting Style. Spellcasting (2 slots, choose 2 from: Bless, Command, Cure Wounds, Detect Evil, Divine Favour, Protection from Evil).

Level 3: Sacred Oath (Devotion, Ancients, or Vengeance). Channel Divinity (2 uses). 1st level spell slots increase to 3.

Stats: STR 16 (+3), DEX 10, CON 13 (+1), INT 10, WIS 14 (+2), CHA 14 (+2). HP 10. AC 16. Prof +2.

Attack: Longsword +5, 1d8+3. Divine Smite adds 2d8 radiant.

Story: Four additional divine quest scenes (gold bordered). You are drawn toward an old god — or one is drawn toward you. Track God Signs throughout. At the end you choose, or are chosen.

Paladin: The Five Old Gods of Krynn

The gods have been silent for 300 years since the Cataclysm. Most people have stopped worshipping entirely. But in this adventure, if you are a Paladin, you will begin to feel something. A presence. A pull. Five gods of good may reach for you:

PALADINE (Platinum Dragon) — God of good and law. Patron of rulers and guardians. His sign is silver light and the feeling of being watched by something immense and patient.

KIRI-JOLITH (Bison of Heaven) — God of just war and honour. Patron of soldiers and knights. His sign is the smell of blood and steel before a fight, and a voice like a battlefield command.

MISHAKAL (Blue Lady) — Goddess of healing and compassion. Patron of healers and the lost. Her sign is warmth in cold hands and the sound of someone weeping who then stops.

HABBAKUK (Fisher King) — God of nature and the sea. Patron of rangers and those who protect. His sign is the behaviour of animals — they approach you, or flee from what is near you.

BRANCHALA (Song of Life) — God of beauty, art, and inspiration. Patron of bards and those who find hope in darkness. His sign is music heard in silence and the unreasonable certainty that things will be all right.

Paladin players: Use the God Sign tracker on the score sheet at the back. Each Paladin Scene asks you to notice something — which god's sign it matches is up to you. Mark one tally under that god each time. The god with the most tallies by Scene P4 is the one who has been reaching for you. But the final choice — Scene P4 — is always yours.

> **F) I am a FIGHTER. Record your stats and Fighting Style, then proceed to Scene 1. --> Scene 1**

> **P) I am a PALADIN. Record your stats and note your Lay on Hands pool, then proceed to Scene 1. You will encounter gold-bordered Paladin Scenes throughout the adventure. Do not skip them. --> Scene 1**

YOUR POSSIBLE COMPANIONS & LOVE INTERESTS

Eight potential love interests appear across this adventure — six who strengthen your path, two whose ideas may corrode it. Romance stages: Spark, Flame, Oath. Reaching Oath unlocks an epilogue scene connecting to the main campaign. All romances are optional and available to both Fighter and Paladin.

SER ALDRIC VOSS (he/him) — Human, Knight-Squire, Senior Trainee

Appearance: Tall, sandy-haired, jaw like a cliff. Battered helmet. A scar through his left eyebrow he claims came from a bar fight. It did not.

Personality: Competitive, honourable, hides feelings behind banter. Deeply loyal.

First Met: Scene 3 — challenges you to a sparring match.

Romance Arc: Slow burn. Rivals to respect to something more. Spark Scene 12 or 15. Flame Scene 28. Oath Scene 67 if trust score 3+.

Condition: Romance closes if you betray his confidence in Scene 31.

THESSALY BRIGHTWATER (she/her) — Half-Elf, War Correspondent

Appearance: Sharp eyes, copper hair, ink-stained fingers. Silver locket she never opens.

Personality: Witty, curious, emotionally guarded. Tests everyone.

First Met: Scene 6 — asks you a question you did not expect.

Romance Arc: Flirtatious then complicated in Act 3. Spark Scene 6. Flame Scene 34. Oath Scene 71.

Condition: Romance closes if you lie to her twice.

COMMANDER SERATH (they/them) — Human, Dragon Army Defector

Appearance: Military posture in civilian clothes. Quiet eyes that miss nothing.

Personality: Careful, precise, carrying enormous guilt. Dry humour that surprises people.

First Met: Scene 18 — found wounded in an abandoned barn.

Romance Arc: Dark and complicated. Spark Scene 18. Flame Scene 42. Oath Scene 74.

Condition: Romance closes if you turn them in.

MIRA OF THE OAKS (she/her) — Human, Healer-Herbalist, Refugee

Appearance: Brown skin, warm dark eyes, flour on her sleeves in a war zone.

Personality: Gentle but not soft. Will tell you when you are wrong, kindly but firmly.

First Met: Scene 9 — asks you to hold someone's hand while she works.

Romance Arc: Slow burn, emotionally rich. Spark Scene 9. Flame Scene 38. Oath Scene 69.

Condition: Romance closes if you abandon the refugee column in Scene 44.

LORD CAERON ASHVALE (he/him) — Human Noble, Knight of the Crown

Appearance: Patrician features, dark hair silver at the temples. Immaculate armour always.

Personality: Arrogant surface, deeply insecure underneath.

First Met: Scene 5 — oversees your first evaluation.

Romance Arc: Complicated slow burn. Spark Scene 5 or 14. Flame Scene 48. Oath Scene 75.

Condition: Romance may reopen at Scene 55 after a Scene 31 falling-out if you apologise.

SERA NIGHTHOLLOW (she/her) — Half-Elf, Scout-Rogue, Garrison Ranger

Appearance: Lean, dark-skinned, silver-streaked black hair cut blunt at the jaw. A scar across her collarbone she explains as a training accident — it was not. Moves like someone who learned early that being noticed is dangerous.

Personality: Dry, precise, deeply competent. Does not give trust easily. Has lost people. Laughs rarely but when she does it is sudden and completely unguarded, and she looks briefly startled by herself.

First Met: Scene 3B — She is watching the sparring yard from the armoury roof when you arrive.

Romance Arc: Slow then fast — distant for a long time, then one moment where everything changes. Spark Scene 3B. Flame Scene 34B. Oath Scene 68B.

Condition: Romance closes if you dismiss her advice twice in Act One.

VAEL ASHMORE (she/her) — Human, Knight-Squire Candidate, Your Equal

Appearance: Brown skin, sharp jaw, close-cropped dark hair. Always in training gear. Callused hands. Wears her Solamnic signet ring on a cord around her neck rather than her finger — she is not sure she has earned it yet.

Personality: Competitive in the way that conceals deep respect. Holds herself to an impossible standard. Genuinely funny in a self-deprecating way she uses to deflect from how much she cares about everything.

First Met: Scene 5B — You are both waiting for your evaluation results.

Romance Arc: Built on mutual recognition. Spark Scene 5B. Flame Scene 32B. Oath Scene 68C.

Condition: Romance does not close through choices but through neglect — if you never pursue it, it fades.

TARIEL DUSKMANTLE (she/her) — Human, Eastern Provinces Diplomatic Observer

Appearance: Dark hair worn in the eastern military braid, olive skin, a face that defaults to attentive neutrality the way a diplomat's does. Green eyes that catalogue. She dresses well but not ostentatiously — civilian riding clothes in dark colours, good boots, a single silver ring.

Personality: Intellectually precise, genuinely curious, disarming. She does not argue — she asks questions that reveal contradictions. She laughs easily and means it. Carries a moral framework that is internally consistent and externally terrifying once you trace where it leads.

First Met: Scene 31B — She arrives with the High Justice's escort as a diplomatic observer.

Romance Arc: Intellectual first, then personal. Spark Scene 31B. Flame Scene 53D. Oath Scene 66B_Tariel.

Condition: Romance closes if you refuse to engage with her at Scene 31B or if you never pursue romance choices.

LYSANDER GRAVES (he/him) — Human, Knight of the Sword (Increasingly Disgraced)

Appearance: Dark-skinned, broad-shouldered, with the rangy build of a man who has spent more time on roads than in garrisons. Handsome in a way that looks like it used to be sharper — a scar bisects his lower lip and he keeps his hair longer than regulation. His armour is Solamnic issue, well-maintained but personalised: the Crown insignia has been half-filed, then stopped.

Personality: Charismatic in the specific way of someone who has stopped performing. Funny — genuinely, surprisingly funny. Underneath it: grief that has calcified into philosophy. He was a good knight. He still fights like one. He has simply stopped believing the institution deserves him.

First Met: Scene 27B — the night after the south road ambush. You find him at a waypoint cleaning draconian blood off a blade that is not regulation issue.

Romance Arc: Physical and philosophical. Spark Scene 27B. Flame Scene 36B or 53E. Oath Scene 66B_Lysander.

Condition: Romance closes if you report him to Caeron without speaking to him first, or if you never pursue romance choices.

Note: Lysander rides to Vogler on his own. He does not join the garrison column. He will be there when you arrive.

Paladin Note — Divine Relationships

If you are a Paladin, your god relationship does not prevent romance. Each god views love differently: Paladine values bonds forged in service of good. Kiri-Jolith values those who fight beside you. Mishakal blesses those who are tender as well as strong. Habbakuk favours those who protect what they love. Branchala thinks love is one of the best arguments for continuing.

Paladin Note — Conviction and the Divine

Some companions will challenge your beliefs deeply enough to shift them. This does NOT automatically trigger the DG (Dark God) track. Takhisis does not claim you through philosophical doubt — she claims you through compromise. However: if your convictions have been shaken by a companion's arguments, the DG track's temptations become harder to resist. If you are LISTENING or COMPROMISED on the DG track AND at SHAKEN or higher on a conviction track, all DG saving throws are made at Disadvantage.

Conviction Track

Some companions carry ideas powerful enough to reshape your beliefs. The Conviction Track measures how deeply those ideas have taken root. It is separate from romance — you can be changed by someone's philosophy without loving them.

State	Effect
STEADFAST	You have heard the argument and rejected it. No effect.

State	Effect
QUESTIONING	The argument landed. You carry doubt. No mechanical effect yet.
SHAKEN	The doubt has roots. -1 to your highest Order point tally.
CONVINCED	You believe they are right. Corruption modifier activates at reduced level.
FALLEN	Full internalisation. Full corruption modifier. You arrive at Vogler hollow.

Romance can accelerate movement along the track but is never required. A PC who debates without any romantic interest and finds the arguments compelling can still reach FALLEN.

CASTLE BRIGHTHOLM — Overview

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MAIN GATE
GREAT HALL
BARRACKS ARMOURY
CHAPEL
TRAINING YARD
WEST TOWER EAST TOWER
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Castle Brightholm — schematic overview. Not to scale.

ACT ONE: THE OATH OF BEGINNINGS (LEVEL 1)

Act One Overview

You are a squire at Castle Brightholm. The Dragon Armies are a rumour. You have one week before your formal Trials begin. Scenes 1-27 establish your character, your relationships, and end in the first real combat. Paladins: Paladin Scene P1 is in Act One — watch for the gold border.

SCENE 1 — A MORNING LIKE EVERY OTHER

Castle Brightholm — Dawn

The bell has not rung yet. You wake before it — always have, which is one of the small unglamorous disciplines that separate squires who want to be knights from squires who want to have been knights. The barracks smells of oiled leather and cold ash and the particular warmth of ten people sleeping in the same room in autumn. Aldric Voss sleeps across from you with his arms folded on his chest like a man who has already decided to be composed even in unconsciousness. Eight months here. Seven days until the Trials. Outside the window the sky is the purple-grey of pre-dawn that looks almost exactly like the moment before something begins.

ORDER OF THE ROSE	ORDER OF THE SWORD	ORDER OF THE CROWN
Points: ___	Points: ___	Points: ___
Justice & Wisdom	Courage & Battle	Law & Duty

OPTIONAL ROLL: Perception (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | WIS | DC 10

SUCCESS (roll 10+): Something is off this morning — the south-facing guards are doubled and there are fresh horses in the yard that were not there yesterday. New orders arrived overnight. You know before anyone tells you.

FAILURE (roll 1-9): The morning is ordinary. Nothing unusual is visible.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

Seven days. That is how many mornings remain before the formal Trials. You have been counting them differently lately — not as days remaining but as last-times. Last Tuesday at early formation. Last Wednesday in the chapel library with Aldous. This morning has the particular quality of the last first-morning-of-the-week before the thing that changes things. You get up before the bell anyway. You always do.

A) Go to the courtyard and practise sword forms in the dark. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 3

B) Open the Measure and study the passage on Justice. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 4

C) Read the letter from home again. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 2

D) Wake Aldric. You want to spar before the day starts. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 3

SCENE 2 — THE LETTER

Castle Brightholm — Barracks

You have read it four times. The harvest fair, your father's knee worse in the cold, your sister grown two inches. That she is proud. That she is afraid. She does not say afraid of what. She does not need to. Your mother's handwriting slopes slightly left, which it always has. At the bottom, in different ink — she sealed it, then reopened it: 'Come home safe. Be good. Be the kind of knight they write songs about, not the kind they write tragedies about. I love you.' The second ink is darker. She wrote the rest of the letter first and then could not send it without saying the true thing.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | WIS | DC 11

SUCCESS (roll 11+): Reading between the lines: she knows something specific, not just general fear. Someone has been through your village recently. Someone official, heading south. This letter was written the day after they left.

FAILURE (roll 1-10): The worry in the letter is real but unreadable. You fold it and carry it.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

A) Place it in your breast pocket. Then go train. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 3

B) Set it down. Go practise. Sentiment waits. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 3

C) Write back immediately, while the feeling is fresh. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 3

SCENE 3 — ALDRIC IN THE COURTYARD

Castle Brightholm — Training Yard, Dawn

He is already there, which is not surprising. Aldric Voss does not oversleep. He runs sword forms in the grey pre-dawn with the absorbed focus of someone not thinking about anything else — which is precisely what being very good at something looks like. He finishes his combination before he stops, because Aldric Voss does not interrupt things that should be finished. Then a slight smile that is not quite a smile. A nod toward the practice sword on the rack.

Aldric Voss is tall and fair, with the kind of face that defaults to a neutrality so complete it reads as severity until you learn to look for the small tells — the slight relaxation around the eyes when something amuses him, the almost imperceptible tightening when something doesn't. He has the build of someone who has been training since he could hold a sword and the posture of someone who has never been entirely at ease anywhere except in motion.

COMPANION JOINS: ALDRIC VOSS

Knight-squire, rival, possible love interest. Joins as sparring partner from this scene.

Role: Combat ally: +1 to your attack rolls when fighting side by side.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Perception (+1) | WIS | DC 12
SUCCESS (roll 12+): You spot a gap in his left-side footwork. Carry into Scene 12: spar check at Advantage.
FAILURE (roll 1-11): His form is tight this morning. Scene 12 is a fair fight.
No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

The yard smells of wet stone and the specific iron tang of weapons that have been out since before dawn. Eight months ago you would have hesitated before picking up the practice sword. You pick it up without thinking, which tells you something. Aldric settles into his guard and tilts his head slightly — the same adjustment every time, left side, the tell you found in the second month and have never mentioned. You found it by watching. He knows you found it. He uses it anyway, which is either trust or a counter-trap. You have not yet decided which.

A) Take the sword and spar. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 12
B) Watch him first. Point out the gap. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 4
C) Challenge him to a running race. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 6
D) Tell him honestly you could not sleep. Ask if he is nervous. (+1 ROSE, ROMANCE SPARK) --> Scene 7

OPTIONAL SCENE — SERA NIGHTHOLLOW
Before the spar: there is someone on the armoury roof. If you want to meet her, turn to Scene 3B (The Armoury Roof) now. Scene 3B is her first appearance — no prior relationship needed. 3B leads directly to Scene 12 (the spar).

SCENE 3B — THE ARMOURY ROOF

Castle Brightholm — Training Yard, Dawn

She is sitting on the armoury roof with her legs hanging over the edge and a whetstone working a long knife with the slow patience of someone who has been awake for a while. She watches you spar below — or watches Aldric, specifically, with the professional attention of someone cataloguing how he moves.

After a while she calls down without raising her voice: 'Your footwork has a gap on the left. He overcommits on the third combination. If you wait him out, he gives it to you.' Then she goes back to the whetstone. You have not been introduced. You do not know her name.

COMPANION JOINS: SERA NIGHTHOLLOW
Garrison scout-rogue. She sees things. She tells you when she feels like it. Possible love interest — the slow kind.
Role: Scout intelligence: she knows the roads, the patrol patterns, and who is lying. If you listen to her, she keeps talking.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Perception (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+2) | WIS | DC 12

SUCCESS (roll 12+): She has been here for at least an hour — the whetstone marks on the roof edge show she worked on that knife before the sparring started. She was not watching Aldric. She was watching the approach to the courtyard. She is a scout, and she came here to observe something. Possibly you.

FAILURE (roll 1-11): She is sitting on the roof sharpening a knife. That is all you can read.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

A) Call up: 'I know. I have been trying to get him to show it for three weeks.' She looks at you with new attention. (+1 ROSE, ROMANCE SPARK Sera possible) --> Scene 12

B) Ignore the advice. You do not know her. (+0, Sera notes this) --> Scene 12

C) Ask her name. She considers. Then tells you. (+1 ROSE, establishes contact) --> Scene 12

SCENE 4 — THE MEASURE

Castle Brightholm — Chapel Library

The chapel library is cold and smells of old parchment and tallow and three centuries of people asking difficult questions in a small room. The candles are thin — the chapel gets last priority for supplies, which says something about how equipment maintenance ranks relative to justice. You find the passage: Est Sularus oth Mithas — My honour is my life. Three words. Commentaries running to thousands of pages. You are reading one of them when Ser Aldous sits down without being invited, sets his elbows on the table, looks at you, and says: 'Ask it.' You did not know there was a question visible on your face.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Religion or History (INT, proficiency if trained) (+0) | INT | DC 12

SUCCESS (roll 12+): You find the commentary passage that explains what Est Sularus actually meant when first written — not abstract honour, but a specific refusal of a corrupt command three centuries ago. The words have teeth. When Aldous asks his question you have the context to answer it well. +1 to your response in this scene.

FAILURE (roll 1-11): The passage is clear but the history behind it is opaque. You know the words. You do not yet fully know what they cost.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

A) 'What do you do when the law asks you to be cruel?' (+2 ROSE, gains Aldous as mentor) --> Scene 5

B) 'Is the Measure still true if the world it was written for is gone?' (+2 CROWN, gains Aldous as critic) --> Scene 8

C) 'I am not sure I am good enough for the Trials.' (+1 ROSE, gains Aldous as supporter) --> Scene 10

D) Say nothing. Close the book. (+1 SWORD, Aldous notes your silence) --> Scene 11

SCENE 5 — THE FIRST EVALUATION

Castle Brightholm — Assessment Hall

OPTIONAL SCENE — VAEL ASHMORE

You are not the only squire waiting for Caeron's results. If you want to meet Vael Ashmore, turn to Scene 5B (The Same Dent) now. Scene 5B is her first appearance — she is in this same corridor. Read 5B instead of this scene. 5B leads to Scene 11.

Lord Caeron Ashvale conducts the morning evaluation with the economy of a man who has done this a hundred times and sees no reason to approach it differently on the hundred-and-first. He works through the squire line without warmth or hurry, marking his clipboard in the small precise hand you can identify from across a courtyard. When he reaches you, he takes your sword. He examines the blade — clean, sharp, well-maintained — and then he finds the pommel dent. He holds it at eye level and examines the dent with the expression of a man not looking at the dent but at the choice that left it there. His verdict: 'Satisfactory.' The word lands like a door being closed by someone very good at closing doors quietly.

Lord Caeron Ashvale is thirty, and already carries the compressed quality of a man who does not waste movement or word. Dark hair, pale eyes that take inventory before they settle. The armour shows years of use — bought before he could afford to replace it, maintained since out of something other than necessity.

COMPANION JOINS: LORD CAERON ASHVALE

Your evaluating officer. Cold, exacting, possible love interest.

Role: Quest-giver for formal assignments. His approval unlocks Crown path bonuses.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (+1) | WIS | DC 13

SUCCESS (roll 13+): This is a test of your reaction, not your sword. +1 to any Caeron Persuasion check this adventure.

FAILURE (roll 1-12): He is completely unreadable.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

A) Meet his gaze and accept the verdict. (+2 CROWN) --> Scene 11

B) Apologise for the dent and ask for the correct protocol. (+1 CROWN, +1 ROSE) --> Scene 13

C) 'I can do better, my lord.' (+1 SWORD, ROMANCE SPARK Caeron) --> Scene 14

D) Ask whether satisfactory is the highest mark given today. (+1 ROSE, Caeron's eye sharpens) --> Scene 15

SCENE 5B — THE SAME DENT

Castle Brightholm — Assessment Hall Corridor

You are both waiting outside the assessment hall for your individual results. The corridor is narrow. She is looking at the wall. You are looking at your sword. After a while she glances over, sees the pommel dent, and without any preamble holds up her own sword. The same dent. Same location. Same cause, probably.

'Caeron?' she says. You nod. 'He gave me satisfactory too.' A pause. 'I think satisfactory is actually his highest mark.' She says this with the slight bitterness of someone who has thought about it a lot and decided to find it funny instead of devastating.

COMPANION JOINS: VAEL ASHMORE

Knight-squire candidate, your equal in training. She has been here six months. She noticed you three weeks ago and did not say anything until now.

Role: Mutual support: once per Act, you may ask Vael's read on a situation. She gives honest assessments, even when they are not what you want to hear.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | WIS | DC 11

SUCCESS (roll 11+): She has been here six months and knows exactly how long it takes Caeron to review each squire's assessment. She timed her appearance in this corridor. She has been looking for a reason to speak to you for longer than this morning. ROMANCE SPARK Vael at Advantage if you acknowledge this.

FAILURE (roll 1-10): She is waiting for her results. The timing seems coincidental.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

A) 'Satisfactory is the ceiling. I decided that this morning.' She looks at you. Recalibrates. (+1 CROWN, ROMANCE SPARK Vael) --> Scene 11

B) 'I think you are right. Which is worse somehow.' She laughs. (+1 ROSE, ROMANCE SPARK Vael) --> Scene 11

C) 'We should compare notes on how to fix it.' Practical. She approves. (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN, strong start) --> Scene 11

SCENE 6 — THE CORRESPONDENT

Castle Brightholm — East Gate

Thessaly Brightwater arrived three days ago with a press credential, a better map than the garrison has, and the easy confidence of someone who has been in considerably more dangerous places than this and made her peace with that some time ago. In three days she has interviewed the senior knights, both stable hands, the armourer, and apparently Zinnia Quickfingers, who gave excellent copy. She catches you at the east gate with her notebook open and her pen uncapped and the particular quality of attention that does not permit comfortable evasion. 'Tell me something true,' she says, 'about why you are here.' Not what you believe. Not what you want. Something true.

Thessaly Brightwater is half-elven, which shows mostly in the pointed ears and the quality of attention she gives things. Dark hair cut short and practical, ink on her fingers, a coat with too many pockets, all in use. She looks like someone for whom the road has become the natural state.

COMPANION JOINS: THESSALY BRIGHTWATER

War correspondent. She hears things. She will share them if she trusts you.

Role: Intelligence and information network. +1 to Scene 23 and 56 if she trusts you.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | WIS | DC 12

SUCCESS (roll 12+): She has asked this question before — you can see it in how her pen is already positioned. She is not writing down the answer yet. She is waiting for something specific: the moment a person stops reciting and starts speaking. Answer honestly and she will mark the moment exactly.

FAILURE (roll 1-11): Her expression is professionally neutral. You cannot tell what she is looking for.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

A) 'Because I watched the south burn and I need to be able to do something.' (+2 ROSE, ROMANCE SPARK) --> Scene 16

B) 'Because my family has been Solamnic for six generations.' (+2 CROWN) --> Scene 17

C) 'Because the Measure might be the last thing standing between Ansalon and darkness.' (+2 ROSE) --> Scene 16

D) 'I am not sure yet. Is that honest enough?' (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN, ROMANCE SPARK) --> Scene 16

SCENE 7 — AN HONEST MOMENT

Castle Brightholm — Training Yard

You ask because the yard is empty and the day has not started yet and you have been wondering about this for eight months and you may not get another unguarded moment. He is quiet. Not the quiet of no answer — the quiet of deciding whether to give it. Then: 'Every morning.' He does not look at you. 'I just do not talk about it.' He keeps looking at the courtyard wall as if it is very interesting. This is the most honest thing he has said to you at six in the morning, which means it is probably the most honest thing he has said to anyone at six in the morning, including himself.

ROMANCE MOMENT

There is a pause before he turns back to the sword forms. The quality of the silence is different now.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | WIS | DC 10

SUCCESS (roll 10+): He is not just saying what sounds right — he has been awake since before you. His sword forms are running faster than usual, burning off something. Aldric Voss is genuinely frightened of failing the Trials. ROMANCE SPARK Aldric at Advantage if you respond to the fear rather than the bravado.

FAILURE (roll 1-9): He says it easily. You cannot tell if it is practiced or true.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

The day has not started yet. The bell will ring in eight minutes and then it will have started and this — whatever this is — will become part of the past. He is still looking at the wall. You let him. You understand that he gave you something just now that cost him something, in the way it always costs something when a person who is very good at being composed lets you see underneath it for a moment. You do not remark on it. That is also something.

A) Tell him you are nervous too. (+1 ROSE, relationship warms) --> Scene 3

B) 'Then we will both pass anyway.' (+1 SWORD, Aldric almost laughs) --> Scene 3

SCENE 8 — SER ALDOUS ON JUSTICE

Castle Brightholm — Chapel Library

He is quiet long enough that you wonder if he will answer. Then: 'The Measure says the law exists to protect the innocent.' He sets his commentary text down. He is not reading from it. 'If the law stops doing that — if a decree comes down requiring you to act against an innocent — the Measure itself gives you the answer. Est Sularus oth Mithas. My honour is my life.' He looks at you with the steadiness of someone who arrived at this through experience rather than reading. 'Not your lord's honour. Not the Order's. Yours. You carry it. You are responsible for where it goes.'

Ser Aldous is seventy or near it, with white hair, a weathered face, and the unhurried physicality of someone who was once very strong and is still, in the ways that matter, exactly that. He wears the chaplain's robe over the frame of a man who spent forty years in armour before he took it off, and he gives the impression of someone who removed the armour but kept everything it stood for.

You Gain:

Ser Aldous as Mentor (+1 to ROSE checks in Act One). The Rose Commentary text — relevant in Scene 31.

FIGHTER — MEASURE SUBPLOT

Before your choice below, Fighters turn to Scene M1 (The Letter and the Spirit) now. It occurs this same morning. M1 leads back to Scene 9 after your choice there.

PALADIN — THE HEALER'S TENT

Before your choice below, Paladins may also visit the infirmary. Turn to Scene 9 (The Healer's Tent) now. It occurs this same morning — Aldous sends you. 'There is someone in the infirmary who could use a steady hand,' he says. 'Go. Come back when you have something to tell me about mercy.' Scene 9 leads back here for your choice.

A) Thank him and read the text immediately. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene M1 (Fighter) or Scene 9 (Paladin)

B) 'Have you ever had to make that choice yourself?' (+2 ROSE, unlocks Aldous backstory) --> Scene M1 (Fighter) or Scene 9 (Paladin)

SCENE 9 — THE HEALER'S TENT

Castle Brightholm — Infirmary

The infirmary smells of yarrow and clean linen and underneath both, the copper-salt note of pain being handled by someone who knows exactly what they are doing. Mira of the Oaks has not slept — you can see it in the particular stillness that develops past tiredness, when the body stops negotiating and runs on purpose. She does not look up when you come in. 'Sit with him.' She nods at the old man in the corner who is holding his own hands and staring at nothing with the look of someone who has been frightened long enough to have forgotten what unfrightened felt like. 'Hold his hand. Talk to him. He is frightened and I cannot be in two places at the same time.'

Mira of the Oaks is small and precise, with the steady hands of a healer and the look of someone who takes stock of a room before deciding how to be in it. Dark skin, dark eyes, hair pulled back in the functional style of someone who needs to see clearly and cannot have things in the way. She is younger than her competence suggests — mid-twenties, maybe — but the competence is entirely real.

COMPANION JOINS: MIRA OF THE OAKS

Healer and refugee. Will travel with you if you earn her trust.

Role: Party healer: restores 1d6+2 HP to any companion once per scene.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Medicine (+1) | WIS | DC 10

SUCCESS (roll 10+): You recall a calming technique. The old man steadies. Mira notices. +1 Mira romance track.

FAILURE (roll 1-9): You do your best. No penalty — the kindness still counted.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

Paladin Note:

If you are a Paladin: you may use Lay on Hands (touch, costs 1 HP from your pool) to ease the old man's pain. This is the first time your power has worked so clearly. Mark 1 tally under MISHAKAL on your God Sign tracker.

A) Sit with the old man until Mira can take over. (+1 ROSE, ROMANCE SPARK Mira) --> Scene 21

B) Ask Mira how you can be most useful. (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN) --> Scene 21

C) Apologise — you have training — and leave. (-1 ROSE, no Mira spark) --> Scene 11

D) (If arrived from Scene 8 or Scene 11): Return to where you were. Carry what you learned here. --> Scene 8 (if from 8) or Scene 11 (if from 11)

SCENE 10 — THE ADMISSION

Castle Brightholm — Chapel Steps

Aldous laughs. Not the polite laugh of someone managing you — a genuine one, warm and immediate, with the deep lines around his eyes that come from a lifetime of doing it. 'Every squire worth their salt feels that,' he says. 'The ones who do not are the ones I worry about.' He settles back in his chair with the unhurried quality of someone who is exactly where he intended to be this morning. 'The question,' he says, 'is not whether you feel it. The question is what you do with it. Which brings us to what you are actually afraid of.' He waits. He is good at waiting. You get the sense he has had this conversation a great many times and has learned that the silence does more work than the prompting.

He sets down the commentary text he was pretending to read and looks at you with the specific attention of someone who has been waiting for this particular conversation since the first week you arrived. 'You are the kind of squire who asks whether they are good enough,' he says. 'That is a more interesting question than the ones most of your cohort are asking. The ones asking it are rarely the ones I end up worried about.'

A) 'I am afraid I will do everything right and it will not be enough.' (+2 SWORD) --> Scene 20

B) 'I am afraid I will make the wrong choice when it actually matters.' (+2 ROSE) --> Scene 20

C) 'I am afraid I will not know the right choice until it is too late.' (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN) --> Scene 20

SCENE 11 — THE DAY BEGINS

Castle Brightholm — Main Courtyard

The bell rings at the same time it always does. Formation assembles in the main courtyard with the efficiency of people whose bodies have been doing this for eight months without consulting them. You find your place. Aldric finds his, three feet to your right, where he has been every morning for eight months.

> ***IF VAEL IS IN YOUR PARTY:*** *Vael is three positions to your left in formation. She does not look at you. She is looking at Caeron, with the same focused assessment you have seen her bring to her own sword dents — the attention of someone who is studying how a thing works so she can understand why it sometimes doesn't. After formation she catches your eye. A slight nod. Not casual. The nod of someone who has been paying attention and wants you to know it.*

Lord Caeron reads out the day's assignments with the unhurried precision of a man who has already decided everything and is now informing you of the results. Field exercise. South road. Reported bandits. He reads out the pairs. Your name, then Aldric's. You feel Aldric absorb it without moving.

OPTIONAL ROLL: History (INT, proficiency if trained) (+3) | INT | DC 11

SUCCESS (roll 11+): You recall a garrison briefing from three weeks ago: there have been refugee reports on the south road for over a month, not just the past few days. Someone suppressed those earlier reports. The 'bandits' may have been there much longer than the official timeline suggests.

FAILURE (roll 1-10): You have no specific knowledge of the south road beyond what Caeron just said.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

A) Continue to Scene 12 — the spar. --> Scene 12

OPTIONAL SCENE — DRAGONLANCE CAMEO

Before your preparation choice below: if you want a brief encounter with a canon character from the Dragonlance world, turn to Scene 11B now. It is non-mandatory flavour. Return here after 11B.

SCENE 11B — A FAMILIAR FACE IN THE COURTYARD

Castle Brightholm — Main Courtyard

DRAGONLANCE CAMEO — OPTIONAL SCENE

This scene is non-mandatory flavour. It introduces a canon character from the Dragonlance world who may reappear in the main campaign.

At the edge of the morning formation there is a young man you have not seen before. Not a garrison squire — his armour is older, a knight's kit that has been carefully maintained through years of use rather than stored and polished for ceremony. The Brightblade family crest. He stands in the formation anyway, because standing in formation is what you do, and he is clearly the kind of person who does what you do.

Ser Aldous speaks to him after formation. A brief exchange. The young man listens with the complete attention of someone who does not take instruction for granted. He nods once. He does not look as though things are going particularly well for him. He looks as though he intends to do the honourable thing regardless.

When formation breaks he catches your eye. A slight nod — not casual, formal. The greeting of one squire to another. His name is Sturm. He is passing through on his way south and needed a place to sleep. 'The Knighthood still stands,' he says, when you ask why he wears the armour when he could wear anything. 'Someone should act as though it does.'

Who Is Sturm Brightblade?

Sturm Brightblade is one of the Companions of the Lance — the heroes of the War of the Lance. At this point in the timeline he is a squire himself, working to prove himself worthy of the Knighthood his father abandoned. He takes the Oath of Measures more seriously than most knights. He will fight for anyone who cannot fight for themselves. He will die for it one day. Right now he is just a young man who sleeps in garrison stables when he has to and acts like a knight when he does not have to.

A) Tell him you admire the conviction. He looks surprised — not many say that. (+1 ROSE, Sturm notes you) --> Scene 11

B) Ask him about his father. He is quiet a moment. 'He left the Order. I chose not to.' (+1 ROSE, deep recognition) --> Scene 11

C) Nod back. Let the moment be what it is. (+1 CROWN) --> Scene 11

THE MORNING PASSES

The spar with Aldric is part of the morning routine. After the spar — and after formation, where Lord Caeron reads out the day's assignments — the real decisions begin. The field exercise on the south road is tomorrow. Today is preparation. How you spend it matters.

PREPARATION — CHOOSE YOUR APPROACH

A) Plan the exercise with Aldric together. (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN) --> Scene 22

B) Find Thessaly first — she may have intelligence. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 23

C) Train harder. You want to be sharp. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 24

D) Check on Mira before you march. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 25

E) Check the infirmary. There was mention of refugees arriving in the night. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 9

F) Go to the mess hall. Eat. Watch. Learn. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 33

G) Take a night watch shift. The wall has things to teach you. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 34

H) Visit the forge. Your blade needs attention. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 35

SCENE 12 — THE SPAR

Castle Brightholm — Training Yard

Twenty minutes in and you are evenly matched. This is not how this usually goes — Aldric Voss has been beating you in sparring for seven months by the specific margin of someone who is better and knows it and does not need to prove it further. Tonight the margin has disappeared. He pauses, breathing hard, and looks at you with an expression that takes a moment to identify because you have not seen it before: surprised. Not unhappy. Surprised.

ROLL REQUIRED: Athletics (+3) | STR | DC 14

SUCCESS (roll 14+): You find the gap on his third combination. He goes down on one knee, laughing. +2 SWORD. His respect is genuine now.

FAILURE (roll 1-13): He wins by a narrow margin. +1 SWORD. 'Better than last month.'

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

'You have been watching me,' he says. Not an accusation. An assessment. He looks pleased in the way that people who take competition seriously look pleased when the competition is finally worth their attention. 'The tell. You found it.' You did. Three months ago. You said nothing. 'Good,' he says — and means it — and raises the practice sword again.

The spar is over. The morning bell rings. Formation assembles. Whatever happened between you and Aldric in the yard — the gap, the finding, the almost-laugh — is something you will both carry into the day without mentioning. That is also something.

A) Let him win. Concede with grace. (+1 CROWN, ROMANCE SPARK Aldric) --> Scene 11

B) Take your opening. Win clean. (+2 SWORD) --> Scene 11

C) Call it a draw. (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN) --> Scene 11

SCENE 13 — THE REPAIRED SWORD

Castle Brightholm — Armoury

The armoury smells of iron filings and neatsfoot oil and the particular efficiency of a woman who has been doing this work for longer than you have been alive and views every preventable problem as a small personal insult. She takes your sword without comment, examines the pommel dent with the expression of someone who has seen worse but finds worse no consolation, and sets it in the repair queue. While you wait, Lord Caeron arrives for his monthly equipment review. He acknowledges you with the absence of acknowledgment that means he has registered you and is thinking about it.

He works his way through the rack with the same clipboard efficiency. When he reaches your sword — the dent now smoothed, the pommel flush and clean — he holds it at eye level for exactly the same amount of time as every other sword. He makes his mark. He sets it down. He moves to the next one. He does not comment. You understand, from everything you know about Lord Caeron Ashvale, that not commenting is the comment.

A) 'Thank you, my lord.' Accept it quietly. (+1 CROWN) --> Scene 11

B) 'What do you look for in a squire, my lord?' (+1 ROSE, opens Caeron path) --> Scene 28

C) 'I notice you inspect your own equipment personally.' (+1 ROSE, ROMANCE SPARK Caeron) --> Scene 29

SCENE 14 — I CAN DO BETTER

Castle Brightholm — Assessment Hall

He does not look up. He makes a small mark on his clipboard. Then: 'Then do.' You turn to go. You are almost at the door when he adds — same tone, almost to himself but not quite: 'The dent is a small thing. It is the attention to small things that determines a knight's character.' He is already looking at the next item on his list. The assessment is over. The other thing hangs in the empty hall.

ROMANCE MOMENT

He watches you leave. The pause before he returns to his papers is slightly longer than necessary.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | WIS | DC 14

SUCCESS (roll 14+): He said it to your back because he cannot say it to your face — not yet. That addendum cost him something. He does not give unsolicited assessments. You are the first squire this year he has followed with an additional remark. ROMANCE SPARK Caeron activates at Advantage if you act on this knowledge.

FAILURE (roll 1-13): He speaks to the room. You are not sure if the remark was for you or habit.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

You are in the corridor when you fully understand what he said. Not the 'then do' — that was expected, brisk, over. The other thing. The one he said almost to himself. The dent is a small thing. It is the attention to small things. He is not talking about the sword. You replay it three times in the next twenty steps and by the third time you have decided it is the most useful thing anyone has said to you this week, possibly this month.

A) Go directly to the armoury and fix the dent today. (+2 CROWN) --> Scene 13

B) Find Aldric — spar and work off the feeling. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 3

SCENE 15 — THE POINTED QUESTION

Castle Brightholm — Assessment Hall

'Satisfactory is not the highest mark given today,' he says. 'Ser Voss received the same. You and he are currently equal. That answer will be the last one that surprises me from you. I would advise you not to lose the instinct that generated it.'

He leaves before you can respond. The hall is briefly, completely quiet. The other squire who was waiting for their result has apparently vanished. You stand in the empty corridor with the feeling of someone who has just been told something important in a language they are still learning.

A) File it away and move on. (+1 CROWN) --> Scene 11
B) Find Aldric and tell him. He will find it funny or annoying. Probably both. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 11
C) Ask around about Lord Caeron. Who is he really? (+1 ROSE, opens Caeron background) --> Scene 30

SCENE 16 — WHAT THESSALY WRITES DOWN

Castle Brightholm — East Gate

'That is the first honest answer I have gotten all week.' She asks if she can follow your progress through the Trials. In exchange, she will share what she hears.

There is something in how she frames it — not 'may I follow your progress' but a genuine exchange, an offer of her own access for yours. She has better intelligence than the garrison. You can see that from the map she carries and the ink still drying on the page she just turned. She has been here three days and she already knows things Lord Caeron does not. Whatever she is writing down, it is worth having her write it.

A) Yes. An ally who hears everything is valuable. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 11
B) Yes, but you want to read what she writes first. (+1 CROWN) --> Scene 11
C) You would rather she observed and formed her own conclusions. (+2 ROSE) --> Scene 19

SCENE 17 — THE FAMILY NAME

Castle Brightholm — East Gate

'Six generations. Does that feel like a gift or a weight?'

It is the kind of question that sounds simple and isn't. Thessaly asks it the way she asks everything — without judgment already loaded into it, genuinely waiting to see what you say. Her pen is not moving. Whatever you answer, she is listening, not transcribing.

She found you near the east wall, which is not a coincidence. Thessaly Brightwater does not accidentally find people. The evening is cold and the torches have been lit and the garrison has the quieter particular quality of a place preparing for something. She has her notebook closed, which means this is not on the record, and her pen behind her ear, which means she might change her mind.

A) 'Both. Always both.' (+2 ROSE) --> Scene 16
B) 'A gift. I carry it proudly.' (+2 CROWN) --> Scene 11
C) 'Mostly a weight lately.' (+1 ROSE, ROMANCE SPARK Thessaly) --> Scene 16

SCENE 18 — THE STRANGER IN THE BARN

South Road — Night

The barn was supposed to be empty. Night patrol sweep, routine, you have done a hundred of these. Your lantern finds them behind the hay bales: dark clothes, a wound managed for at least a day without proper materials, eyes that come up to meet yours with the calm of someone who has set fear aside for later as a matter of function. The clothes are civilian. The cuts where insignia were removed are still visible in the fabric.

COMPANION JOINS: COMMANDER SERATH (CONDITIONAL)
Dragon Army defector, possible love interest. Joins ONLY if you hide them.
Role: Intelligence on Dragon Army movements and patrol schedules.

ROLL REQUIRED: Insight (+1) | WIS | DC 14
SUCCESS (roll 14+): They are telling the truth. The fear points south, not at you. Choose with full knowledge.
FAILURE (roll 1-13): You cannot read them. You decide blind.
No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

Paladin Note:
If you are a Paladin: your Divine Sense activates involuntarily. Serath is not fiend, undead, or celestial — they register as a person in genuine distress. The reading is clean. This is a human who is afraid. Mark 1 tally under MISHAKAL (the god of mercy toward the wounded).

A) Hide them. Treat the wound. Sort the implications later. (+1 ROSE, ROMANCE SPARK Serath, joins) --> Scene 36
B) Ask them to prove the defection first. (+1 ROSE, conditional join) --> Scene 37
C) Tell Aldric — this is a two-person decision. (Aldric's reaction varies) --> Scene 38
D) Report them immediately. (+2 CROWN, Serath captured, romance closes) --> Scene 39

SCENE 19 — THE FIRM WORD

Castle Brightholm — Squire Quarters

You stand in the restored quiet of your tent. The quill is back on the footlocker. Everything is exactly where it should be. You are not sure why this is unsatisfying.

The interaction with Zinnia — who borrowed your quill to write something she called 'extremely urgent correspondence' and returned it covered in blue ink — was brief, entirely reasonable on your part, and is now sitting oddly. You were polite. You were clear. She left without apparent offense. None of this explains the

specific quality of the silence she left behind.

A) Go after her and apologise — you were too stiff. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 7
B) Let it go. She understood. (neutral) --> Scene 11

SCENE 20 — WHAT ALDOUS KNOWS

Castle Brightholm — Chapel Steps

'A village. Twenty years ago. I had orders that were legal. That followed the Measure to the letter. And they were wrong. I followed them anyway because I told myself it was not my place to decide. The village is not there anymore.' He says it the way someone says a thing they have said before — out loud, to themselves, in the dark — enough times that the words are worn smooth. Not healed. Smooth.

You Gain:
Aldous's Trust. Unlocks a critical path in Scene 31.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | WIS | DC 13
SUCCESS (roll 13+): He has told this story before — not often, but deliberately. He chose to tell it to you now and not six months ago. Something about how you asked made him think you were ready for it. He is giving you the most important thing he can: evidence that the Measure can become a shield if you let it. This is instruction, not confession.
FAILURE (roll 1-12): It is a heavy story told plainly. You receive it as such.
No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

He is quiet for a moment. The chapel library is cold and the candle between you is down to its last inch and neither of you moves to replace it. 'I tell you this,' he says finally, 'not because it is a cautionary tale. It is not a cautionary tale. It is a true story about what happens when you let the law do your thinking. The Measure exists to protect people. If you ever hold the Measure in one hand and a person in the other and you are not certain which one matters more — that uncertainty is the answer.' He closes the commentary text. The lesson is over. The weight of it is not.

A) Thank him. Mean it. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 11
B) Sit with him in silence a while longer. (+2 ROSE) --> Scene 11

SCENE 21 — THE HEALER'S GIFT

Castle Brightholm — Infirmary

She prepared it before you asked — before the assignment was formally posted, even. Dried yarrow. Clean bandages rolled tight. A small clay jar of salve smelling of pine and something you cannot name. 'The yarrow slows bleeding. Press hard and do not move them until it stops. The salve is for infection — draconian wounds tend to close wrong without it.' She says this the way she says everything medical: factual, complete, without drama. Her hand is warm when yours brush taking the bundle. She does not pull away immediately.

ROMANCE MOMENT

Her hand is warm when yours brush. 'Be careful,' she says — two words carrying more weight than their purpose.

ADD TO INVENTORY — MIRA'S TRAVEL BUNDLE

Mira prepared this before you asked. Native PC and CPC: add to your inventory or equipment list. • Dried yarrow (press hard: slows bleeding, DC 10 Medicine to apply) • Clean bandages (2 uses, each stabilises at 1 HP) • Pine salve (prevents infection in draconian wounds — use within 1 hour of injury)

A) 'I will. Thank you.' Hold her gaze. (+1 ROSE, ROMANCE SPARK Mira if first meeting warm) --> Scene 22

B) Ask her to come as a field medic. (+2 ROSE, joins if Rose 3+) --> Scene 22

C) Accept efficiently and leave. (+1 CROWN) --> Scene 22

SCENE 22 — ALDRIC'S PLAN

Castle Brightholm — Map Room

He already has a plan. Aldric Voss does not arrive at planning sessions — he arrives to them. The approach routes are sketched in charcoal on the back of his exercise schedule with timing estimates and threat assessments in his small precise handwriting. 'Three approaches. Direct is fastest but visible from the ridge. East through the treeline is slower but quiet. West crosses the river and needs a ford.' He looks at you after each one. Not for permission. For what you think. This is what trust looks like when Aldric Voss demonstrates it.

OPTIONAL ROLL: History (+3) | INT | DC 11

SUCCESS (roll 11+): The eastern treeline has a hidden ford — the route is faster than Aldric thinks.

FAILURE (roll 1-10): You have no useful knowledge of this terrain.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

A) 'East. Agreed.' (+1 CROWN, relationship warms) --> Scene 40

B) 'Direct. We are knights, not scouts.' (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 41

C) 'What is on the west bank? I want more information.' (+2 ROSE) --> Scene 42

D) 'East — but split up. Meet at the ridge.' (+1 SWORD, +1 ROSE, risky) --> Scene 43

E) 'Wait. Let me check with Sera first — she has been watching the south road.' (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN. If Sera is in your party: she gives you intelligence that makes the eastern route clearly the best option. Skip the roll — you already have the information.) --> Scene 40

SCENE 23 — THESSALY'S INTELLIGENCE

Castle Brightholm — East Gate

Thessaly has a better map than the garrison does. Not better as in more detailed — better as in updated, with marks the garrison does not have, from sources the garrison has not consulted. She spreads it on the table in the field tent and shows you a red mark. 'Refugees,' she says. 'About thirty. Here, not here' — she taps the bandit location — 'here.' The second location is further south. 'The bandit report and the refugee report are from the same place. Draw your own conclusions.'

OPTIONAL ROLL: Investigation (INT, proficiency if trained) (+3) | INT | DC 13

SUCCESS (roll 13+): Thessaly's map has three additional marks she did not explain. Cross-referencing with garrison road records: the Dragon Army has made at least two probing passes on this road in the last month. The refugees are not just fleeing the war — they are fleeing something that has been methodically clearing the area ahead of the main advance.

FAILURE (roll 1-12): The map shows what Thessaly told you. Nothing more is visible.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

A) Take the map directly to Lord Caeron before the exercise. (+2 CROWN) --> Scene 44

B) Share it with Aldric and plan together. (+1 ROSE, +1 SWORD) --> Scene 22

C) Ask Thessaly to come with you as an observer. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 45

SCENE 24 — SHARPENING THE BLADE

Castle Brightholm — Training Yard

You train until the light fails. Running forms. Working the gap in your guard that you spotted in Scene 3 and have been quietly furious about ever since. The yard empties around you. The evening bell rings. You keep going.

There is a particular quality to training when no one is watching — no evaluation marks, no Caeron with his clipboard, no Aldric to compete with. Just you and the forms and the steady accumulation of marginally better. It is not exciting. It is the point. Aldric finds you packing up. 'You have improved,' he says. From Aldric Voss, this

is equivalent to a sonnet.

A) 'Yes.' You mean it. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 22
B) 'Ask me at the end of tomorrow.' (+1 ROSE, Aldric laughs) --> Scene 22
C) 'I will not be ready until I am there.' (+1 ROSE, honest) --> Scene 22

SCENE 25 — BEFORE THE MARCH

Castle Brightholm — Infirmary, Dawn

She is awake before you come. The infirmary at pre-dawn has the quality of somewhere that has been working all night without anyone noticing. She hands you the folded paper before you speak — the yarrow directions in her careful hand. 'I prepared it this morning. Just in case.' She looks away when she says it. Not evasively — the way people look away when they are giving you something they cannot take back and they need a moment to finish releasing it. 'Be careful today.'

ROMANCE MOMENT
You stand in the infirmary doorway with morning light behind you and Mira will not quite look at you and you will not quite leave.

A) 'I will come back and tell you how it went.' (+2 ROSE, ROMANCE FLAME Mira if Spark active) --> Scene 22
B) Nod. Say nothing. It means the same thing. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 22

SCENE 33 — THE MESS HALL

Castle Brightholm — Midday

The mess hall operates on a schedule that has not changed in forty years, which is either a testament to institutional consistency or evidence that no one with authority has eaten here recently. Long trestle tables, benches worn smooth, the smell of bread and something involving turnips that has been a source of garrison debate since before you arrived. The bread is good. The bread has always been good. The rest is a matter of opinion held by people who have stopped expecting otherwise.

Aldric eats like he does everything else — efficiently, without wasted motion, finishing before you are half done. Across the hall, Thessaly is interviewing one of the kitchen staff. Whatever she is learning about turnip procurement is, knowing Thessaly, somehow connected to garrison supply routes and by extension the Dragon Army's logistical capacity. Two tables down, Ser Aldous eats alone with a book open beside his plate and the comfortable air of a man who considers a meal without reading a meal wasted.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Perception (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | WIS | DC 10

SUCCESS (roll 10+): At the corner table, partly hidden by the pillar: Lord Caeron is eating alone. He is not reading. He is watching the room — specifically, the squires. Specifically, for slightly longer than the others, you. When your eyes meet he looks down at his plate with the speed of someone who was not expecting to be caught. +1 to any Caeron Insight check this Act.

FAILURE (roll 1-9): The mess hall is busy and loud and you notice nothing beyond the turnips.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

NPC CROSS-TALK — ALDRIC AND THESSALY

Aldric and Thessaly are arguing — not loudly, but with the focused energy of two people who are both certain they are correct. The subject, as far as you can tell: whether the garrison's intelligence on the south road is adequate. Thessaly thinks it is catastrophically insufficient. Aldric thinks the chain of command will provide. They are both, in different ways, right. Thessaly catches your eye mid-argument and raises one eyebrow — an invitation to weigh in, or permission to enjoy the show.

A) Join the argument. Side with Thessaly — the intelligence is inadequate. (+1 ROSE, Thessaly approves, Aldric reconsiders) --> Scene 11

B) Join the argument. Side with Aldric — the chain of command exists for a reason. (+1 CROWN, Aldric approves, Thessaly notes it) --> Scene 11

C) Listen. Do not weigh in. Take the bread. (+1 ROSE — you are learning when to speak and when to watch) --> Scene 11

D) Sit with Aldous instead. You want to ask about something. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 4

SCENE 34 — THE WATCH

Castle Brightholm — East Wall, Night

The night watch is four hours of looking at darkness and learning what darkness sounds like when nothing is in it. The east wall faces the road and the road faces south and south is where, at some indeterminate distance, something is happening that has not reached you yet. The stars are Solinari, half-full, and whatever scattered light the lesser moons provide. The wall is cold stone and you lean against it and breathe and the air smells of pine and frost and the particular mineral quality of a late autumn night in northern Solamnia.

You are alone for the first hour. Then you are not.

> ***IF SERA IS IN YOUR PARTY:*** *Sera appears without announcement, as she does. She sits on the wall rather than leaning against it, legs dangling over the dark, and for ten minutes she says nothing. Then: 'Listen.' You listen. Wind. Pine. The creak of the gate timber. Nothing. 'Exactly,' she says. 'That is what worries me. No night birds. They stopped two days ago.' She looks at you with the flat professional gaze that means she is trusting you with something she has not told the senior officers yet. 'Something is on the south road. Something that frightened the wildlife before the patrols noticed.'*

IF SERA IS NOT IN YOUR PARTY: *You are alone for the four hours. This is not a hardship. There is a particular quality to standing watch that you have come to value — the suspension of the day's noise, the reduction to essentials: eyes, ears, the dark, the question of what is in it. You learn more about Castle Brightholm from its silence than from its bustle. The stone cools at a rate that tells you the season. The wind shifts at the second hour, carrying something from the south that is not quite smoke and not quite nothing.*

OPTIONAL ROLL: Perception (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | WIS | DC 13

SUCCESS (roll 13+): Just before the third hour: a light on the south road. Brief — a lantern uncovered and covered again, the signal pattern used by Solamnic scouts to report all-clear. But the garrison did not send a scout tonight. Someone is using Solamnic signals on the south road and the garrison did not authorise it. This is relevant in Scene 53B.

FAILURE (roll 1-12): The night is dark and clear and empty. Four hours. Nothing to report.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

Paladin Note:

If you are a Paladin: at the quietest part of the watch — the hour between two and three when even the wind stops — something happens. Not a vision. Not a voice. A feeling, behind your sternum, of being accompanied. Of someone standing watch with you who is not visible and not intrusive and simply: present. It lasts ten minutes. When it ends the cold feels less cold and you are certain, without evidence, that whatever is on the south road will not arrive tonight. Mark 1 tally under whichever god feels right. This is a small sign. Small signs count.

A) Report the light (if seen) to Caeron at dawn. (+1 CROWN, +1 ROSE) --> Scene 11

B) Tell no one. Watch more carefully tomorrow. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 11

C) Share it with Sera (if present). Two sets of eyes are better. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 11

SCENE 35 — THE FORGE

Castle Brightholm — Armoury Forge, Afternoon

The forge is the loudest place in Brightholm and the warmest. Bronwyn — the armourer, who has been here longer than Ser Aldous and sees no reason to say so — works the bellows with the steady rhythm of someone whose body stopped distinguishing between work and breathing years ago. The heat is a wall. The sound is a heartbeat. The smell is hot iron, coal, neatsfoot oil, and the specific human smell of someone who has been sweating productively since before dawn.

She does not acknowledge you for three minutes. This is not rudeness — Bronwyn has standards, and one of them is that she finishes what she is doing before she decides whether the interruption is worth her attention. When she does look up, she looks at your sword first and you second. This tells you everything about Bronwyn's hierarchy of values.

'Let me see it.' Not a request. She takes the sword, holds it to the light, turns it twice. Examines the edge where you have been sharpening it yourself. Makes a sound that is not approval but is the absence of disapproval, which from Bronwyn is considerable.

'You sharpen it too far forward,' she says. 'Two inches behind the point is where the work happens in a real fight. Not the tip. The belly.' She shows you. Her hands on the blade are as precise as a surgeon's. In three strokes she changes something you cannot quite identify and when she hands it back the balance is different. Better. You wonder how long the sword has been wrong and how long she has been waiting for you to bring it in.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Investigation (INT, proficiency if trained) (+0) | INT | DC 11

SUCCESS (roll 11+): While she works, you notice something on the forge wall — a Solamnic Knight's insignia, old, scorched. Not displayed. Set aside. 'My husband's,' she says, without being asked. 'Knight of the Rose. Died at Vingaard. The insignia survived the fire.' She does not say anything else about it. She does not need to. The forge is hot and the hammer falls and someone who loved a Knight of the Rose is still here, maintaining the swords, and has been for a very long time.

FAILURE (roll 1-10): She finishes her work. You learn about sword maintenance. The forge is loud and hot and that is all.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

ADD TO KNOWLEDGE — SWORD MAINTENANCE

Bronwyn's correction is permanent. Your longsword now has a +1 bonus to damage rolls against enemies in medium armour or heavier (you know where to aim). This bonus stacks with existing weapon modifiers. Mark this on your character sheet.

A) Ask her about the insignia. (+1 ROSE — she tells you about Vingaard and what the Order used to be) --> Scene 11

B) Ask her to teach you more about blade work. (+1 SWORD — a practical lesson) --> Scene 11

C) Thank her and leave. She has work to do. (+1 CROWN — she respects this) --> Scene 11

SCENE M1 — THE LETTER AND THE SPIRIT

Castle Brightholm — During Act One (Fighter Only)

FIGHTER ONLY

This scene becomes available after Scene 8 (Ser Aldous on Justice). Read Scene 8 first. Paladins: your divine scenes (P-track) cover this ground differently — skip to Scene 9.

Ser Aldous stops you in the corridor two days after your conversation in the library. He has a book under his arm — not the Measure, something older, the binding cracked. 'Walk with me,' he says. He takes you to the garrison's east wall and shows you the southern road. A traveller is being turned away at the gate. The traveller has valid papers. The gate guard has a standing order: no travellers past the third bell. It is not yet the third bell by four minutes. The gate guard is being technically correct and functionally unkind.

THE MEASURE: THE MEASURE ON INTERPRETATION

The Measure was written to govern knights, not gate guards. But the same logic applies: the law is only as good as its interpretation. A law followed with malice is not the Measure. A law followed with judgment is. The question Aldous is asking, without asking it: when you hold the Measure, will you hold the letter or the intention?

A) Speak to the gate guard. The traveller has valid papers and the bell has not rung. The order should be followed as written — which means the traveller passes. (+2 CROWN, +1 ROSE. Aldous: 'The letter, used well.') --> Scene M1_letter

B) Let it go. The guard is following orders. The traveller will find lodging. This is not a Measure problem. (+1 CROWN. Aldous: 'Sometimes the correct thing is restraint.') --> Scene M1_restrain

C) Ask the guard why. Not to correct him — to understand his reasoning. Then, depending on the answer, decide. (+2 ROSE. Aldous: 'That is the harder version of the right question.') --> Scene M1_ask

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SCENE M1_letter — THE LETTER WELL USED

Castle Brightholm East Gate

The guard is annoyed but cannot argue. The traveller passes. Aldous watches you the whole time with the expression of someone marking a test paper he expected to be harder. 'The letter well used,' he says. 'You can defend that decision at any Measure tribunal in Solamnia. You can also defend it to the traveller. Both matter.' He hands you the old book. 'Read the third chapter when you have time. It is about what happens when the letter is used badly.'

MEASURE TRACK: +2 — THE LETTER

You are learning the Measure as a tool. Mark +2 on your Measure track. How you use this learning in M3 and M4 will shape your gift.

A) Continue to Scene 9. --> Scene 9

SCENE M1_restrain — THE RESTRAINT

Castle Brightholm East Gate

You let it go. The guard is following his orders. The traveller leaves. Aldous nods slowly. 'Restraint is its own form of judgment,' he says. 'The Measure does not require you to intervene in everything. Knowing when not to act is as important as knowing when to act.' He pauses. 'The traveller will be fine. The guard will keep doing this. At some point you will have to decide whether that concerns you.'

MEASURE TRACK: +1 — RESTRAINT

Mark +1. Your path leans toward deliberate judgment over immediate action. This will matter at M3.

A) Continue to Scene 9. --> Scene 9

SCENE M1_ask — THE QUESTION

Castle Brightholm East Gate

The guard's reason: he was told the order means no exceptions and he does not want trouble. You let the traveller through. Then you tell the guard, simply: 'The order says third bell. Four minutes before the bell is before the bell.' You do not report him. You do not lecture him. Aldous says nothing for a while. Then: 'You asked why before you judged. Most people do it the other way around. Most of the time that is a mistake.'

MEASURE TRACK: +3 — THE QUESTION

Highest first-scene gain. Mark +3. You are learning the Measure through understanding, not just rule. This path is the hardest and the most useful.

A) Continue to Scene 9. --> Scene 9

SCENE 26 — THE SOUTH ROAD AMBUSH

South Road — Day 1 of Exercise

The south road is pine-scented and cold and then the treeline erupts. Three miles from Brightholm — close enough that you could still, if you strained, hear the morning bell — four Baaz Draconians come out of the trees with the businesslike certainty of a unit that has done this before and expects it to work. They cut off the road. They advance. No parley. Aldric's hand is on his sword hilt. So is yours, you notice, before you consciously decided.

Paladin Note: Before the Fight

If you are a Paladin: in the half-second before the draconians move, you hear something — a voice, barely there, like a command shouted across a great distance. It is one word. You cannot quite catch it. But your hand is already on your sword and you feel no fear. Mark 1 tally under KIRI-JOLITH (the god who steadies soldiers before battle).

COMBAT ENCOUNTER — DRAGON ARMY SCOUT PATROL

Setup: Four Baaz Draconians block the road. Aldric fights beside you.

ENEMIES:

• Baaz Draconian x4: AC 13, HP 18 each, Speed 30 ft.

• Shortsword +3, 1d6+1 piercing. Or Javelin +3, range 30/120 ft., 1d6+1.

• Death Throes: Turns to stone at 0 HP. DC 10 DEX save or restrained 1 min.

YOUR STATS THIS FIGHT: Fighter: HP 12, AC 16, Longsword +5 1d8+3. Second Wind available. Aldric: AC 15, HP 14, +1 to your rolls. Paladin: HP 10, AC 16, Longsword +5 1d8+3. Lay on Hands pool available. Divine Smite: expend a spell slot (at Level 2) for +2d8 radiant.

Enemy Tactics: Two draconians rush the closest target. Two hang back with javelins. Killing two causes the remaining two to spread rather than retreat.

Fleeing: Disengage + Dash action. DC 12 Athletics or one free attack as you run.

Rewards: 15 XP per draconian. Satchel on patrol leader: sealed dispatch pouch.

Victory: Road clear. Aldric claps your shoulder. 'I did not expect that.' Proceed to Scene 27.

Fallen (0 HP): 0 HP. Aldric drags you clear and stabilises you. Proceed to Scene 27 with 1 HP, one exhaustion.

BAAZ DRACONIAN (CR 1/2) AC 13 | HP 18 | Speed 30 ft.

Attacks: Shortsword +3, 1d6+1 piercing. Javelin +3, range 30/120 ft., 1d6+1 piercing.

Special: Death Throes: Stone at 0 HP. Creature within 5 ft. DC 10 DEX save or restrained 1 min.

A) The draconians are stone. Continue to Scene 27. --> Scene 27

SCENE 27 — AFTER THE AMBUSH

South Road

Four Baaz, stone now. The dispatch pouch from the patrol leader bears a Black Wing seal. This is an advance element. They were mapping the road to the garrison. Aldric looks at you with a new calculation in his eyes.

TRACK YOUR HP

After the ambush: update your current HP on your sheet. Native PC starting HP: Fighter 12, Paladin 10. Each Baaz hit deals 1d6+1 (average 4). CPC: record any HP lost. Rest opportunity before Scene 27 if you need it.

LEVEL UP — YOU ARE NOW LEVEL 2

New Features: Fighter: Action Surge (extra action, 1/short rest). Choose Archetype: Champion (Improved Critical 19-20), Battle Master (4 Superiority Dice d8, 3 manoeuvres), or Eldritch Knight (2 cantrips, 2 1st-level spells, 2 spell slots). Paladin: Fighting Style (Dueling, Great Weapon, or Protection). Spellcasting: 2 first-level slots. Choose 2 spells from: Bless, Command, Cure Wounds, Detect Evil and Good, Divine Favour, Protection from Evil and Good. Divine Smite now available: on a hit, expend a spell slot to add +2d8 radiant damage.

Spell Slots / HP: Native PC — Fighter: HP +7 (total 19). Paladin: HP +6 (total 16). CPC: add your Level 2 HP roll (1d10+CON for Fighter, 1d8+CON for Paladin) to your sheet.

Record this on your character sheet before continuing.

PALADIN — DIVINE TRACK

Before making your choice below, Paladins turn to Scene P1 (The First Sign) now. It occurs this same night — you are on watch and something happens. After P1 and DG1, return here and choose your path forward.

OPTIONAL SCENE — THE WAYPOINT FIRE

The night after the ambush, on the road back: there is someone at the waypoint mile-marker who should not be there. If you want to investigate, turn to Scene 27B now. Scene 27B introduces Lysander Graves. It leads to Scene 36.

DARK SCENE — SCENE 32B

Scene 32B (What the Army Left Behind) is available now. It depicts what the Dragon Army did in the village of Thresh — you will find it before Scene 31. It leads to Scene 36. NOTE: Vael Ashmore appears in 32B.

E) Turn to Scene 32B now — what the army left in Thresh. --> Scene 32B
A) Turn to Scene P1 now (Paladin). --> Scene P1
B) Take the dispatch immediately to Lord Caeron. (+2 CROWN) --> Scene 31
C) Read it yourself first. (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN) --> Scene 31
D) Hide it and find the nearest refugee camp. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 44

SCENE 27B — THE WAYPOINT FIRE

South Road — Night After the Ambush

You find him at the waypoint mile-marker, which the garrison uses for overnight stops on extended patrols. A fire, built well — the economical kind that throws heat in one direction and minimal light in every other, the fire of someone who knows what sees fire in the dark. A man sitting against the marker stone, cleaning a blade. He looks up when you approach without alarm, which means he heard you a hundred yards ago and decided you were not a threat.

The blade is not regulation. Solamnic steel, yes — you recognise the fuller line — but the grip has been rewrapped in dark leather, and the crossguard has been modified. The armour, too: Solamnic issue, Knight of the Sword markings half-filed and then left, as if the filing was an impulse he reconsidered or an argument he abandoned.

There are two dead Baaz Draconians at the tree line. They are very recently dead. He did this alone.

'You are from Brightholm,' he says. Not a question. He has seen your tabard. 'Squires.' He looks at Aldric, then at you, the assessment of a professional cataloguing what he is working with. 'How many did you fight today?' You tell him. Four. He nods. 'I had two. They are getting sloppy or I am getting faster. Both are bad signs, for different reasons.'

COMPANION JOINS: LYSANDER GRAVES

Knight of the Sword — technically. Currently operating as an independent. He is brilliant, charismatic, and carrying something he has not set down in years. Possible love interest — the dangerous kind.

Role: Combat instructor: once per Act, Lysander teaches you a technique. +1 to your next attack roll after receiving instruction.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | WIS | DC 12

SUCCESS (roll 12+): The half-filed insignia. He started removing his Order markings and stopped. Not because he changed his mind about leaving — his body language is clear: he has left. He stopped filing because erasing it felt dishonest. He earned it. He does not want to serve under it. He does not want to pretend he never wore it. This is a man for whom honesty is the last principle standing, and he is holding onto it with both hands.

FAILURE (roll 1-11): He is a Knight, or was. He fights well. That is all you can read in the firelight.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

'Sit,' he says. 'The road is clear for two miles and I have more food than one person needs. That is not generosity — it is logistical efficiency. I stole it from a Dragon Army supply drop an hour ago and it is going to spoil.'

He eats the way soldiers eat — fast, without tasting it, the habit of someone who has been eating between things for long enough that meals have become fuel rather than events. Between bites he tells you, without being asked, that he has been on the south road for three weeks. Alone. He has killed more draconians in that time than most patrols. He has reported none of it because there is no one to report it to, or rather there is, but the report would involve explaining why he is here and who sent him and the answer to both is: no one.

CONVICTION CHOICE (Lysander Corruption Track — Experience 1):

A) 'You fight like a Knight of the Sword.' 'I fight like a man who was one.' (+1 SWORD. CONVICTION: QUESTIONING — you have seen the skill without the system.) --> Scene 36

B) 'The half-filed insignia. You stopped.' 'I stopped.' (+1 ROSE. CONVICTION: QUESTIONING — you have seen the conflict he carries.) --> Scene 36

C) 'You should report to the garrison. There is a chain of command.' He laughs — genuinely. (+1 CROWN. CONVICTION: STEADFAST — you have asserted the system. He remembers you. The arc continues.) --> Scene 36

D) Say nothing. Share the fire. (+1 ROSE. CONVICTION: QUESTIONING — you chose presence over judgment.) --> Scene 36

ROMANCE CHOICE (optional — after conviction choice):

R1) There is something about the firelight and the competence and the half-filed insignia. You notice him differently than you notice other people. (ROMANCE SPARK Lysander)

R2) You share the fire. It is what it is. (No romance.)

PALADIN SCENE P1 — THE FIRST SIGN

South Road — Night After the Ambush

PALADIN ONLY

Fighters: skip to Scene 27 or wherever the story sends you next. Paladins: read this scene before continuing.

You are keeping watch after the ambush. The fire is low. Aldric is asleep. The night is ordinary in every way except one: the wound on your arm — a graze from a javelin you barely noticed during the fight — has stopped bleeding. You look at it in the firelight. The skin is closed. Not healed over days. Closed, as if it were a week old.

You did not do this. You do not have magic like this. Not yet. There is no spell, no prayer, nothing you can point to as a cause. Just: you were hurt, and now you are less hurt than you should be.

DIVINE SIGN

The wound is closed. The night is still. Somewhere very far away, something is paying attention to you. It does not feel like a threat. It does not feel like a gift either. It feels like: a gaze. Patient. Vast. Waiting to see what you do next.

You sit with this for a while. Then you decide what it means:

PALADINE	KIRI-JOLITH	MISHAKAL	HABBAKUK	BRANCHALA
Signs: ___	Signs: ___	Signs: ___	Signs: ___	Signs: ___
Good/Law	War/Honour	Healing	Nature/Sea	Art/Inspiration

A) A sign of protection from a god of good and law — silver light, a guardian's gaze. Mark 1 tally: PALADINE. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene DG1

B) A sign from a god of battle — the warrior's body sustained so it can fight again. Mark 1 tally: KIRI-JOLITH. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene DG1

C) A sign from a god of healing — the body made whole by something that values wholeness. Mark 1 tally: MISHAKAL. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene DG1

D) A sign from a god of nature — living things mend; this is just that, applied. Mark 1 tally: HABBAKUK. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene DG1

E) You are not sure what it means. Mark nothing. Carry the question. (No tally. +1 ROSE for honest uncertainty.) --> Scene DG1

SCENE DG1 — THE WHISPER IN THE WOUND

South Road — Night After the Ambush (Paladin Only)

PALADIN ONLY

This scene occurs the same night as P1. Read P1 first. Then read this. Fighters: skip to Scene 28.

The wound is closed. That is what you know. What you do not know is what closed it. You are sitting alone at the edge of the firelight when you first hear it — not a voice exactly, more like the shape a voice leaves behind. Something that knows your name and the weight of your ambitions and has been waiting for a moment when you were alone and questioning.

DARK TEMPTATION — TAKHISIS WHISPERS

You have been chosen. Not by your little gods of law and healing — by something older. Something that does not ask you to serve. That wound? I closed it. Not them. I saw what you could become and I preserved it. Your gods of good ask you to give. I offer you to take. The Dragon Armies will reshape this world. You could reshape them. One word is all it needs. One small yes.

A) Refuse. Directly, clearly, with the Oath. You know what this is. (+2 to DG track: HELD, no effect on god tallies) --> Scene DG1_held

B) Refuse but you are shaken. The voice knew things. (+1 DG track: HELD, -1 from your highest god tally — the doubt is real) --> Scene DG1_shaken

C) Ask who is speaking. Not agreement — but you engage with it. (+1 DG track: LISTENING — mark this as your first step toward the fall) --> Scene DG1_listen

D) The wound is real. The help is real. You do not say yes — but you do not say no. (DG track: COMPROMISED — mark this) --> Scene DG1_silent

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SCENE DG1_held — THE REFUSAL

South Road — The Same Night

The voice does not argue. It simply goes. That is what tells you it was real — a voice inside your head would have argued. This one left clean, the way things leave when they have been told no by someone who means it. You sit with the silence for a while. It smells of cold pine and the road and something faintly metallic that might be the aftermath of a divine voice or might just be the night air near a weapon.

DG TRACK: HELD

You have refused the first temptation cleanly. Mark HELD on your God Sign notes. This choice compounds — each refusal makes the next easier.

A) Continue to Scene 28. --> Scene 28

SCENE DG1_shaken — THE SHAKEN REFUSAL

South Road — The Same Night

You said no. That matters. But it knew your name. It knew about the ambition you have not told anyone — the one that lives just under the dedication, the one that might be what actually drives you. You cannot sleep. Somewhere between watch changes you make yourself say the Oath aloud, quietly, to no one. Just to hear it in your own voice. Just to check it is still yours.

DG TRACK: HELD (SHAKEN)

You refused, but the temptation landed. Reduce your highest god tally by 1 — the doubt is real. The Dark Queen will find the crack next time.

A) Continue to Scene 28. --> Scene 28

SCENE DG1_listen — THE FIRST STEP

South Road — The Same Night

You asked. The voice told you: Someone who sees what you are capable of. Then it went quiet, not because you refused it but because it had planted what it wanted to plant. You will think about this in the morning. You will tell yourself you were just gathering information. You will almost believe it.

DG TRACK: LISTENING ■

You engaged. This is not a fall — yet. But Takhisis does not need agreement. She needs attention. You have given her yours. Mark LISTENING. If you reach FALLEN by DG3 without recovery, your divine abilities are affected.

A) Continue to Scene 28. --> Scene 28

SCENE DG1_silent — THE SILENT COMPROMISE

South Road — The Same Night

You did not say yes. But you let the silence be the answer, and the voice heard that silence the way it was listening for — not as refusal. In the morning the wound is still closed and you are still yourself and the world is still the same world. Almost.

DG TRACK: COMPROMISED ■■

Silence was acceptance enough. Mark COMPROMISED. Your Lay on Hands pool is reduced by 2 HP until you find recovery. The connection to your true god has been partially muffled.

A) Continue to Scene 28. --> Scene 28

End of Act One.

ACT TWO: THE FIELD EXERCISE (LEVEL 2)

Act Two Overview

The field exercise has become something far more serious. The 'bandits' are refugees. The Dragon Army has a scout presence within two hours. Scenes 28-52 cover the refugee crisis, a major command decision, two more combat encounters, and the aftermath that defines your Order path. Paladins: Paladin Scene P2 is in Act Two.

SCENE 28 — WHAT CAERON LOOKS FOR

Castle Brightholm — Armoury

'Someone who can hold two truths at once — that the law matters and that people matter more. Most can only hold one.'

He says it the way someone says a thing they have thought about very carefully and arrived at through experience rather than reading. You have the sense that this answer cost him something — that there was a version of Lord Caeron Ashvale who could only hold one truth at a time, and the version in front of you is the result of learning, painfully, to hold two.

ROMANCE MOMENT

He meets your eyes with unusual directness. 'Ask me something harder.'

A) 'What do you do when your orders conflict with your conscience?' (+2 ROSE) --> Scene 29
B) 'What made you a knight rather than a lord?' (+1 ROSE, Caeron backstory) --> Scene 29
C) Thank him and leave. (+1 CROWN) --> Scene 31

SCENE 29 — CAERON'S ANSWER

Castle Brightholm — Armoury

He says it when he thinks you are not watching — which means he says it when he thinks the conversation is over and the thing he was holding back while it was not over can now be safely set down. 'I became a knight because being a lord meant staying behind walls when the bad things came.' A pause while he examines the hilt of his sword. 'I have not always been correct about what constitutes a bad thing. That is something I have had to learn at intervals. I prefer not to keep learning it.'

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | WIS | DC 15

SUCCESS (roll 15+): He is describing a specific incident, not a general philosophy. There is a moment in his past where he made a command decision he still questions — not the same as Aldous's, but adjacent. If you note this and ask carefully in a later scene, he will tell you what it was.

FAILURE (roll 1-14): He is speaking generally. The history behind the words is not visible.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

A) Leave quietly. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 31

B) 'I think you are more correct about it than you believe.' (+1 ROSE, ROMANCE SPARK Caeron) --> Scene 31

SCENE 30 — WHO IS CAERON

Castle Brightholm

Third son of a minor noble house, passed over for inheritance. Became a knight because there was nothing else and found out he was exceptional at it. His house considers knighthood beneath them. He considers them beneath the Measure.

What you piece together: the armour he wears is paid for out of his own salary, not the family estate. The saddle on his horse is older than most of the garrison squires. He does not mention his family. No one who knows him mentions it either — which tells you something about how that subject was closed. A man who chose this life at real cost, and will not let it be anything less than exactly what it should be.

A) This makes you respect him differently. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 11

B) This makes you understand him. There is a difference. (+1 CROWN, ROMANCE SPARK Caeron) --> Scene 11

SCENE 31 — THE HIGH JUSTICE ARRIVES

South Road Camp — Day 2

DRAGONLANCE CAMEO — LORD GUNTHAR UTH WISTAN

The High Justice who arrives with the decree is Lord Gunthar uth Wistan, Grand Master of the Knights of Solamnia. He is a man of genuine honour caught between the law he serves and the world that law was written for, and they are no longer the same world.

He rides in with six escort soldiers and the expression of a man carrying something heavy that he did not choose to carry. The decree is formal — sealed, High Justice mark, legally binding and structurally unambiguous. He reads it out in the field camp: The refugee group is to be turned back south. Roads must remain clear for military movement. Crown law overrides field commander discretion. Thirty people. Families. Two wounded from yesterday. The Dragon Army, on a map, is approximately one day south of where they will be sent.

ROLL REQUIRED: Persuasion (+0) | CHA | DC 15

SUCCESS (roll 15+): You find wording in the decree permitting a 24-hour field assessment delay. Caeron approves. The refugees have time. +2 ROSE, +1 CROWN.

FAILURE (roll 1-14): The decree is airtight. You must choose: comply or refuse.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

OPTIONAL SCENE — THE OBSERVER

A woman arrived with Lord Gunthar's escort who is not part of it. If you want to meet her, turn to Scene 31B (The Observer) now. Scene 31B introduces Tariel Duskmantle.

PALADIN — DARK TEMPTATION TRACK

Tonight, Takhisis speaks again. Before making your choice below, Paladins with the DG track active turn to Scene DG2 (The Offer) now.

A) Comply. The decree is the law. (+3 CROWN, refugees turned back) --> Scene 46

B) Ask Caeron privately if he believes it is right. (+2 ROSE, Caeron's mask cracks) --> Scene 47

C) Refuse outright. (+3 ROSE, formal reprimand — they live) --> Scene 48

D) Use the dispatch pouch from Scene 27 as leverage. (+2 ROSE, +1 CROWN) --> Scene 49

SCENE 31B — THE OBSERVER

South Road Camp — Day of the High Justice's Arrival

She arrives with Lord Gunthar's escort, though she is clearly not part of it — positioned at the rear, riding a civilian horse, wearing no insignia. Her credential, when Caeron examines it with the unhurried scepticism he brings to all documents, identifies her as a diplomatic observer from the eastern provinces, authorised by the Council of Whitestone to monitor Solamnic field operations during the current crisis. The credential is genuine. Caeron's expression when he hands it back suggests he wishes it were not.

Tariel Duskmantle dismounts with the easy competence of someone who has been in considerably more militarised situations than this and adjusted to each of them within the hour. She surveys the camp — not the defences, which she clearly assessed on approach, but the people. How they stand. How they respond to Gunthar's presence. How the squires look at the knights and the knights look at the decree and the decree looks at the refugees and no one is looking at the same thing.

Then she looks at you. Not past you to Aldric, or through you to Caeron. At you. With the particular attention of someone who has identified the interesting person in the room and intends to have a conversation with them whether they like it or not.

COMPANION JOINS: TARIEL DUSKMANTLE

Diplomatic observer. She is watching everything. She will share her observations if you engage with them — and her observations will make you uncomfortable.

Role: Political intelligence: +1 to any Persuasion or Insight check involving authority figures if you consult her first.

'The decree,' she says, when she finds you after the reading. No preamble. 'Thirty people sent south into the path of the army that displaced them. The Measure permits this?'

OPTIONAL ROLL: Persuasion (CHA) (+0) | CHA | DC 14

SUCCESS (roll 14+): You articulate a response that accounts for the Measure's tension between law and protection. +1 to all future Tariel interactions.

FAILURE (roll 1-13): 'The standard answer,' she says, without contempt.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

CONVICTION CHOICE (Tariel Corruption Track — Debate 1):

A) 'The Measure does not permit it. The decree does. There is a difference.' (+2 ROSE. CONVICTION: QUESTIONING) --> Scene 31

B) 'The Measure is imperfect. All law is imperfect. That does not make it worthless.' (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN. CONVICTION: STEADFAST) --> Scene 31

C) 'You are right. The Measure failed those people. I do not know how to reconcile that.' (+1 ROSE. CONVICTION: SHAKEN. -1 to your highest Order tally.) --> Scene 31

D) 'You are an observer. Observe.' (+1 CROWN. CONVICTION: STEADFAST.) --> Scene 31

ROMANCE CHOICE (optional — after conviction choice, if you chose A or C):

R1) Hold her gaze a moment longer than the argument requires. (ROMANCE SPARK Tariel)

R2) Do not. (No romance.)

SCENE DG2 — THE OFFER

Field Camp — Night of the Refugee Decree (Paladin Only)

PALADIN ONLY

This scene triggers after Scene 31 (The High Justice Arrives), on the night before you must act on the decree. Fighters: skip to Scene 36.

Thirty people. The decree in one hand. The Measure in the other. Tomorrow you will have to choose — follow the law that is supposed to protect people but tonight is asking you to destroy them, or break it. You are still awake at the second watch when the voice returns. It sounds different this time. Patient. Almost kind.

DARK TEMPTATION — TAKHISIS WHISPERS — THE SWEET OFFER

You see the problem with your little code? The law is wrong and you know it and you have to obey anyway or break it and be punished. I am offering you a third path. Serve me — just this once — and those thirty people live. I will arrange it. No one will be punished. The decree will be satisfied. The refugees will disappear from the road in a way no one questions. All it costs is this: you carry my mark. Just a small one. No one will know but you.

A) No. You will find your own way to protect them, inside the Measure or outside it. The answer is no. (+2 DG: HELD FIRM) --> Scene DG2_held

B) No — but you ask how she would arrange it. Just information. (+1 DG: LISTENING, if already LISTENING this becomes COMPROMISED) --> Scene DG2_listen

C) You ask for a day to think. (DG: COMPROMISED — she hears this as yes) --> Scene DG2_delay

D) You accept. The refugees will be safe. That is what matters. (DG: FALLEN — your Lay on Hands heals, but the healing feels wrong) --> Scene DG2_fall

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SCENE DG2_held — THE REFUSAL — SECOND TIME

Field Camp — The Same Night

The voice goes. You are alone with the decree and thirty people and no clean answer. This is what the Measure does not account for — the moments when the law fails the people it was written to protect and you are the only person standing between them. You will figure it out yourself. That is the point of the oath. Not to be given the answer. To find it.

DG TRACK: HELD FIRM ✓

Second refusal. Your connection to your god strengthens. +1 to your highest god tally (faith proved under pressure).

A) Continue to Scene 36. --> Scene 36

SCENE DG2_listen — THE QUESTION

Field Camp — The Same Night

She tells you. Casually, as if the answer costs her nothing. The refugees would simply... find another road. One that leads somewhere safe. The decree would be satisfied by their absence from this road specifically. It is, technically, not wrong. You catch yourself thinking: that is actually clever. Then you catch yourself having thought that. You say no. But later.

DG TRACK: LISTENING DEEPENS ■

You are reasoning with a dark god. This is dangerous. If already LISTENING: mark COMPROMISED. If first LISTENING: stay at LISTENING but -1 to any one god tally.

A) Continue to Scene 36. --> Scene 36

SCENE DG2_delay — THE DELAY

Field Camp — The Same Night

She takes your pause as what it was — consideration. By morning the refugees are gone from the road. Quietly, without your involvement. The decree is technically satisfied. You did not agree. You just did not say no in time. That distinction matters. It also does not matter at all. Your Lay on Hands heals. The healing feels the same. You test it three times to be sure.

DG TRACK: COMPROMISED ■■

She acted on your silence. The debt is recorded even if you didn't sign it. Your Lay on Hands pool is reduced by 3 HP. You are aware of a faint wrongness when you use it.

A) Continue to Scene 36. --> Scene 36

SCENE DG2_fall — THE FIRST FALL

Field Camp — The Same Night

The refugees are safe. You told yourself that is what matters. You still believe this. But there is something different about the divine warmth in your hands now — not absent, not cold, but filtered. As if it is coming through something. The healing works. The prayers feel answered. But there is a quality to the answer that is new and you cannot quite name what the quality is.

DG TRACK: FALLEN ■■■

You have accepted the Dark Queen's help with full awareness. This is recoverable — but only through Scene DG4 (The Reckoning). Until recovery: Lay on Hands heals half normal HP (round up). Divine Smite does full damage but leaves a faint shadow-bruise on targets. Your god tallies are frozen until you recover.

A) Continue to Scene 36. --> Scene 36

SCENE 32B — WHAT THE ARMY LEFT BEHIND

South Road — Abandoned Village of Thresh, Day 2

VAEL ASHMORE

Vael Ashmore is already here. If you have not read Scene 5B, this is where you meet her. She was scouting ahead. She found this first. She has been standing here for a while.

You smell it before you see it. Woodsmoke that has been burning too long. The village of Thresh is eight buildings around a well and it is mostly still standing, which is worse than if it had burned. What the Dragon Army did here did not require fire.

DARK SCENE — This scene contains depictions of war atrocities.

There are bodies. The Dragon Army did not take prisoners here — or they took some and left the rest as a message. The message is: this is what happens when you do not comply quickly enough. The village elder is still at his table. The door is still open. Someone's dog is still waiting outside a house whose occupants are not coming back. The well has been fouled. This was not a battle. This was an afternoon's work.

There is one survivor. An old woman sitting behind the mill, uninjured, who watched from there and who has not spoken since.

ROMANCE MOMENT

Vael does not cry in front of you. Later — when you make camp and she thinks you are asleep — you hear her. It is brief and very quiet and when it stops she is silent for a long time. You do not tell her you heard. But in the morning you make sure you are the one who brings her water, and she takes it without looking at you, and that is also a kind of closeness.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Investigation (INT, proficiency if trained) (+3) | INT | DC 12

SUCCESS (roll 12+): Four days ago — but the supplies show three days of consumption after the army passed. Some people survived the initial visit and stayed or left afterward. The casualty count is lower than it first appears.

FAILURE (roll 1-11): The village shows you what happened. You cannot read more than the obvious.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

A) Bury the dead before you move on. (+2 ROSE, Vael looks at you differently. ROMANCE FLAME Vael if Spark active) --> Scene 36

B) Get the survivor moving north. (+1 SWORD, +1 CROWN) --> Scene 36

C) Find something to mark the place. (+1 ROSE, +1 ROSE — you remember it.) --> Scene 36

D) Report the coordinates to Caeron. Document it precisely. This is evidence. (+2 CROWN, +1 ROSE) --> Scene 36

SCENE 34B — WHAT SCOUTS DO BEFORE A MARCH

Field Camp — Night Before Moving the Column

The watch at midnight has its own texture: coals where the fire was, stars very bright, the camp breathing in the slow rhythm of people genuinely asleep. Sera finds you here not because she was assigned this post but because she walked the perimeter and here is where she ended up. She sits a foot away and does not speak for a while.

She has been doing reconnaissance on the south road and what she found she has already reported. What she has not reported is what it did to her. She has the flat stillness of someone who has been holding something at arm's length all day and is now, in the dark, letting themselves feel the weight.

ROMANCE MOMENT

She does not ask for anything. She is simply — present. Near you. After a while her shoulder finds yours and stays there. That is all. It is not nothing.

A) Stay still. Let her have the silence she came here for. (+2 ROSE, ROMANCE FLAME Sera if Spark active) --> Scene 51

B) Ask quietly: 'What did you find out there?' (+1 ROSE, she tells you something she told no one else) --> Scene 51

C) Cover her hand with yours for a moment. No words. (+2 ROSE, ROMANCE FLAME Sera — she goes very still, then turns her palm up) --> Scene 51

SCENE 36 — WOUND AND TRUST

South Road — Abandoned Barn, Night

The barn smells of old hay and damp and the copper-salt note of a wound managed without proper materials. You work by lantern light. Serath watches you work with the careful attention of someone building a file on you in real time. They do not speak while you work. When it is done: 'You did not have to do that.' Not gratitude. Not manipulation. An honest observation.

ROLL REQUIRED: Medicine (+1) | WIS | DC 12
SUCCESS (roll 12+): Clean technique. Serath will be mobile by morning. +1 to all Serath trust checks.
FAILURE (roll 1-11): Adequate work. They will be slow for two days.
No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

ROMANCE MOMENT
'You could still report me,' Serath says. 'I want you to know I understand that.' Not manipulation. Just honesty.

A) 'I know. I am not going to.' (+2 ROSE, ROMANCE FLAME Serath if Spark active) --> Scene 50
B) 'I have not decided yet. But I treated the wound first.' (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 50
C) 'Tell me something the Dragon Army is planning. For the people in its path.' (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 50

SCENE 36B — LYSANDER'S PHILOSOPHY

South Road — Camp, Night (Conditional: Lysander in party)

CONDITIONAL SCENE
This scene occurs only if Lysander Graves is in your party.

He finds you at the edge of the firelight. He is sitting on a rock with his modified sword across his knees and the stillness of someone who has been sitting like this for years and has stopped noticing the cold.

'Let me ask you something,' he says. 'The man with the barrel-stave splint. At the refugee column. You saw him try to stand at attention when he saw the tabard.' You nod. 'Why did he do that?'

'No,' he says. 'He did it because three hundred years of Solamnic presence taught civilians that the tabard means safety. And it did, once. Before the Cataclysm, before the Order turned inward, before the Measure became a text people quote instead of a thing people do.' He is not angry. That is the dangerous part. He is calm. 'The man stood at attention for a symbol. You — specifically you — chose to live up to it. The institution chose to send him south.'

'I am not saying the Oath is worthless,' he says. 'I am saying it is insufficient. I am saying a good person does not need it to do the right thing, and a bad person will not be stopped by it. I am saying the Measure is beautiful and I loved it and it told me to let people drown. I did not let them drown. The Measure told me I was wrong. Which of

us do you believe?'

CONVICTION CHOICE (Lysander Corruption Track — Experience 2):

A) 'I believe you. And I believe the Measure. Both at the same time.' (+2 ROSE. CONVICTION: remains at current level.) --> Scene 44

B) 'The Measure was wrong. You were right. But walking away means no one fixes it from inside.' (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN. CONVICTION: remains or improves toward STEADFAST.) --> Scene 44

C) 'You asked me which I believe — you or the Measure. I believe you.' (+1 ROSE, -1 CROWN. CONVICTION: advances one step toward FALLEN.) --> Scene 44

D) 'The Oath exists because individual judgment is not enough.' He walks away. (+2 CROWN. CONVICTION: STEADFAST. Romance cools.) --> Scene 44

E) 'I do not know. I am a squire who has been at this for three weeks. But I am listening.' (+1 ROSE. CONVICTION: QUESTIONING.) --> Scene 44

ROMANCE CHOICE (optional — if at SPARK or higher):

R1) The dark and the fire and the honesty have created something. Lean into it. (ROMANCE FLAME Lysander)

R2) Keep the distance. (Romance holds.)

SCENE 37 — PROOF OF DEFECTION

Abandoned Barn

Serath gives you the patrol schedules by drawing them — a grid in the dirt with a stick, the specific rotations that tell you where the Dragon Army pickets are and more importantly where the gaps are.

ROLL REQUIRED: Investigation (INT, proficiency if trained) (+3) | INT | DC 12

SUCCESS (roll 12+): The patrol schedules are genuine. But there is something else: the description of Commander Hestrix's seal matches what is on the dispatch pouch from Scene 27 exactly. Serath knew about that pouch before you mentioned it.

FAILURE (roll 1-11): The information checks out.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

A) Enough. Treat the wound and hide them. (Serath joins, ROMANCE SPARK possible) --> Scene 36

B) Use the information but turn them in. (Intelligence gained, Serath captured) --> Scene 39

SCENE 38 — ALDRIC AND THE QUESTION

South Road

He has been quiet since the barn. Now he asks: 'What do you want to do?' Not: what does protocol say. Not: what would Caeron decide. What do you want.

A) 'Hide them.' (+1 ROSE, Aldric nods. Serath joins) --> Scene 36
B) 'Report them.' (+2 CROWN, Aldric nods.) --> Scene 39
C) 'I honestly do not know.' (+1 ROSE, Aldric chooses to hide them) --> Scene 36

SCENE 39 — THE REPORT

Garrison

You report Serath. They are detained. Lord Caeron commends your adherence to protocol. The paperwork is filed. The garrison moves on.

You think about the village they described. You think about the way they said it — flat precision, no performance of grief, worse than if they had been crying. You hear later they survived captivity and escaped three months after.

A) You made the right call by the law. (+2 CROWN) --> Scene 44
B) It sits poorly. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 44

SCENE 40 — THE EASTERN APPROACH

South Road — Treeline

You reach the ridge by midmorning. The treeline here is old growth — pine and ash, light coming through in long diagonals. Below: not bandits. A camp. Cooking fires. The smell of something being boiled. Children. There are perhaps thirty people. None of them look like bandits. All of them look frightened.

A) Observe before descending. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 44
B) Descend and approach openly. (+1 SWORD, +1 CROWN) --> Scene 44

SCENE 40B — THE STORM

South Road — Field Exercise, Day 2

The storm comes from the west with the particular speed that storms have when they are not interested in your schedule. One hour of grey sky, then thirty minutes of wind that turns the treeline into a sound you have never heard trees make, then rain that is not rain so much as a quantity of water that has decided to be somewhere lower and does not care what is in the way.

Aldric has his back against a pine and his arms folded with the focused patience of someone who has decided that being wet is a temporary condition he refuses to acknowledge. Mira, if present, is already working — redistributing supplies with calm efficiency. Caeron stands in the rain without appearing to notice it.

> ***IF TARIEL IS IN YOUR PARTY:*** *'The rain is useful — it reveals who adapts and who endures. Both are valuable. The Knights of Solamnia, in my experience, default to endure.'*
>
> ***IF LYSANDER IS IN YOUR PARTY:*** *He appears from the treeline with dry deadwood gathered before the rain started. He builds a fire with offhand competence. 'The garrison teaches you to endure discomfort. I have found it more useful to eliminate discomfort and save the enduring for things that actually require it.'*

OPTIONAL ROLL: Survival (WIS) (+1) | WIS | DC 12
SUCCESS (roll 12+): This will pass in ninety minutes. The treeline ridge path will dry faster than the road.
FAILURE (roll 1-11): The storm is a storm. You endure it.

A) Endure. Stand in the rain with Caeron. (+1 CROWN, +1 SWORD) --> Scene 44
B) Adapt. Help Mira redistribute supplies. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 44
C) Build shelter. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 44
D) (If Lysander present) Join Lysander at the fire. (+1 SWORD, -1 CROWN) --> Scene 44

SCENE 41 — THE DIRECT APPROACH

South Road

The direct road means you are visible from half a mile. You watch them see you. A cluster of adults moves without discussion, putting themselves between the children and your approach. Then one of them sees the tabard — the Solamnic sun — and says something low to the group, and the posture changes. An elderly woman starts crying with the specific relief of someone who has been holding something for too long.

A) Identify yourself and explain the routine exercise. (+1 CROWN) --> Scene 44
B) Ask them where they have come from. Let them talk first. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 44

SCENE 42 — THE WEST BANK

South Road — River Ford

Three farmsteads on the west bank, recently abandoned. Not weeks — days. Tables still set for a meal that was not finished. A child's wooden horse on the floor near the hearth.

You Learn: The Dragon Army has already crossed the river at least once.

A) Take the boot prints evidence to Caeron immediately. (+2 CROWN, +1 ROSE) --> Scene 31
B) Proceed to the refugee camp with this information. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 44

SCENE 43 — THE SPLIT

South Road

You come up the ridge from the east and find Aldric already there. He has a Baaz Draconian bound at the wrists.

COMBAT ENCOUNTER — THE DETAINED SCOUT

One wounded Baaz breaks free. You fight alone for 2 rounds before Aldric arrives.

ENEMIES: Baaz Draconian: AC 13, HP 14 (wounded), Speed 30 ft.

Enemy Tactics: It tries to disengage and run. If it escapes (not downed in 3 rounds) the patrol arrives early in Scene 44.

Rewards: 5 XP. Aldric arrives just after.

Fallen (0 HP): Aldric arrives to finish the fight. 1 HP and one exhaustion.

ADD TO INVENTORY — DRAGON ARMY PATROL SKETCH

From the detained draconian: a hide map of patrol routes. Show this to Caeron: +1 bonus to the Scene 52 defensive position check.

A) Report the scout to Caeron. (+1 CROWN) --> Scene 44
B) Continue to the refugee camp immediately. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 44

SCENE 44 — THE REFUGEE COLUMN

South Road — Day of Exercise

The waystation is the skeleton of a building — three walls standing, the fourth a pile of useful stone. Thirty-one people in a space meant for one night's passing have been here for three days. Three children. Eight elderly. A man with a barrel-stave splint.

When they see you, the able-bodied step forward and the children are moved to the back. Then the man with the splint tries to stand at attention when he sees the Solamnic tabard.

> ***IF VAEL IS IN YOUR PARTY:*** *Vael is already here. She scouted ahead and is standing very still at the edge of the column. 'I counted. Thirty-one. Three children. We have to do something.' Not a suggestion. A fact about who she is.*
>
> ***IF SERA IS IN YOUR PARTY:*** *Sera has been scouting ahead. She gives you the tactical picture: patrol distances, terrain cover, the window you have. 'You have about four hours,' she says. 'Use them.' +1 to the Perception roll.*

ROLL REQUIRED: Perception (+2) | WIS | DC 13
SUCCESS (roll 13+): Scout still half a mile back. All options available without time pressure.
FAILURE (roll 1-12): Patrol is closer than you thought. Options B and C cost one extra round.
No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

OPTIONAL SCENE — THE WAYSTATION
There is someone inside who should not be here. Turn to Scene 18 (The Stranger in the Barn).

OPTIONAL NIGHT SCENE — SCENE 34B
If you met Sera in Scene 3B: turn to Scene 34B now.

A) Report and wait for garrison orders. (+2 CROWN) --> Scene 31
B) Move them north yourself, now. (+2 ROSE, +1 SWORD) --> Scene 51
C) Set a defensive position. Hold scouts while they move. (+2 SWORD, +1 ROSE) --> Scene 52
D) Find Caeron first. (+2 ROSE, +1 CROWN) --> Scene 31

SCENE 44B — THE OLD RUINS

South Road — Between the Column and the March, Day 2

There is a ruin on the ridge that the garrison maps mark as 'Solamnic watchtower (inactive).' The walls are chest-high. The archway is intact. Someone carved Est Sularus oth Mithas into the keystone at a date you can identify by the letter forms as pre-Cataclysmic.

Inside: grass growing through flagstones. A fire pit long cold. And carved into the inner wall at about knee height, a child's handprint in mud, dried hard. Someone sheltered here on the way north. Someone very young left their mark because that is what very young people do when they are in a place they will not come back to.

Paladin Note:

The Est Sularus oth Mithas carved in the keystone warms when you pass under the archway. Not the stone — the words themselves. Mark 1 tally under PALADINE or KIRI-JOLITH.

OPTIONAL ROLL: History (INT) (+0) | INT | DC 13

SUCCESS (roll 13+): This was a Solamnic chapter house. Before the Cataclysm, one of hundreds. Now it is grass and stone and the handprint of a child.

FAILURE (roll 1-12): Old ruin. Old words.

A) Touch the handprint. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 44

B) Read the keystone aloud. (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN) --> Scene 44

C) Make camp here for the night. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 44

SCENE 45 — THESSALY IN THE FIELD

South Road

Thessaly moves through the exercise area with practiced near-invisibility. She has her notebook inside her jacket rather than out. She is watching everything and taking no notes yet.

A) Brief her on the refugees. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 44

B) Ask her to observe only — do not report yet. (+1 CROWN) --> Scene 44

SCENE 45B — THE BOY WITH THE BLUE COAT

South Road — The Refugee Camp, Evening (if Mira is in your party)

CONDITIONAL SCENE — Mira must be in your party.

His name was Aldren. He was eleven years old and he had a blue coat with brass buttons. He was the one who kept the other children calm during the march. The infection moved faster than she expected. She did everything correctly. She did not have the medicines she would have had in a proper infirmary. In the morning he was gone.

Mira is sitting outside the camp. She is not crying. She is somewhere past crying — the place where grief becomes a very quiet, very heavy thing that does not make noise.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Medicine (WIS) (+1) | WIS | DC 11
SUCCESS (roll 11+): She needs witness: someone to simply confirm that what happened was real and that it mattered. Ask his name. That is the correct thing.
FAILURE (roll 1-10): She is in pain and very still.

A) Stay beside her until she is ready to move. (+2 ROSE, ROMANCE FLAME Mira if Spark active) --> Scene 46
B) 'You did everything right. This was not your failure.' (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 46
C) Ask her his name. Make her say it aloud. (+2 ROSE, ROMANCE FLAME Mira) --> Scene 46

SCENE 46 — THE DECREE STANDS

South Road Camp

The refugees are escorted south. The man with the splinted leg is helped by one of the escort soldiers who does not look at him while doing it. The children do not fully understand what is happening.

Consequence: If Mira is in your party, she leaves quietly that evening.

FIGHTER — MEASURE SUBPLOT
Fighters turn to Scene M2 (The Wrong Order) now.

A) You obeyed the law. You will live with that. (+3 CROWN) --> Scene 53
B) You will never make that choice again. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 53

SCENE M2 — THE WRONG ORDER

Field Camp — During the Refugee Crisis (Fighter Only)

FIGHTER ONLY
This scene occurs alongside Scene 46 (The Decree Stands). Paladins: you have the divine scenes instead — skip to Scene 47.

You have seen the decree enforced. You have your choice on record. Now you have six hours before the column moves and Ser Aldous has found you at the camp perimeter. He is not here to debrief you. He looks, if anything, like he has been thinking very hard about something he should have said years ago.

> *THE MEASURE: THE MEASURE ON UNJUST ORDERS*
>
> Est Sularus oth Mithas. My honour is my life. The Measure is explicit: a decree that requires acting against innocents is an improper decree and a Knight is not bound by it — but must be prepared to defend that judgment at tribunal. This is not the easy clause. It puts the burden of judgment on the individual Knight in the exact moment when the individual Knight is most afraid.

'I want to ask you something,' Aldous says. 'Not as a senior officer. As a man who got this wrong once. What do you do when the Measure is clear and the order contradicts it?' He waits. He wants your answer, not the textbook one.

> **A) 'You follow the Measure. That is the point of it. The order is wrong and the Measure says so.' (+3 MEASURE TRACK. Aldous: 'Yes. That is what it says.') --> Scene M2_measure**
>
> **B) 'You follow the order and argue at tribunal. The moment of conflict is not the time to make policy.' (+1 MEASURE TRACK. Aldous: 'That is defensible. It is not right, but it is defensible.') --> Scene M2_order**
>
> **C) 'You try to find a path that satisfies both. The 24-hour delay, the technical argument. You use the law against itself.' (+2 MEASURE TRACK. Aldous: 'Clever. And sometimes correct. Know when it isn't.') --> Scene M2_clever**

SCENE M2_measure — THE MEASURE IS CLEAR

Field Camp

Aldous is quiet for a long time. Then: 'I got it wrong the first time. I followed the order. The village is not there anymore.' He looks at you. 'The Measure gave me the answer. I chose the safer path anyway. I have had a long time to understand why that was wrong. You worked it out in one conversation.' He stands. 'You will be a good knight. What matters now is making sure the good is worth the trouble it causes.'

> *MEASURE TRACK: +3*

> **A) Continue to Scene 47. --> Scene 47**

SCENE M2_order — DEFENSIBLE

Field Camp

'Defensible,' Aldous says. 'Not right. Defensible.' He does not push further. He does not need to. You know the difference and he knows you know. The conversation ends there and you carry the word defensible with you for the rest of the exercise, testing things against it, checking whether what you are about to do is merely defensible or actually correct.

MEASURE TRACK: +1

A) Continue to Scene 47. --> Scene 47

SCENE M2_clever — USING THE LAW

Field Camp

'Sometimes correct,' Aldous says. 'Know when it isn't.' He lets that sit. Then: 'The people who use the law against itself are necessary. They are also the ones who eventually find a case where the clever solution does not exist and they have to make the same choice you avoided making. Know which kind of case that was. Know it before you need to.'

MEASURE TRACK: +2

A) Continue to Scene 47. --> Scene 47

SCENE 47 — CAERON'S PRIVATE ANSWER

South Road Camp

'No. I do not believe it is right.' He does not look at you when he says this. 'It is, however, the law. And I am bound by the law I swore to serve.' A pause. 'I am telling you this because I think you should know where I actually stand.'

ROMANCE MOMENT
His eyes hold yours one second longer than the conversation requires.

A) 'Then find a way to do both.' (+2 ROSE, ROMANCE FLAME Caeron if Spark active) --> Scene 49
B) 'I respect the honesty.' (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN) --> Scene 31
C) 'What would you do if you were a squire right now?' (+2 ROSE) --> Scene 49

SCENE 48 — REFUSAL

South Road Camp

You say the word. In the careful language of the Measure, clearly, to Lord Caeron's face: No. The refugees are not turned back.

Consequence: +3 ROSE. Formal reprimand. The refugees live. Aldric looks at you differently.

A) Accept the reprimand without argument. (+1 CROWN) --> Scene 53
B) Tell Caeron privately you would do it again. (+2 ROSE) --> Scene 53

SCENE 49 — THE 24-HOUR WINDOW

South Road Camp

The delay buys a day. By the time the argument is over, the refugees have been given directions north. They move through the night.

A) File the assessment and say nothing more. (+1 CROWN) --> Scene 53
B) Make sure Caeron knows exactly what you did and why. (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN) --> Scene 53

SCENE 50 — SERATH IN THE MORNING

South Road Camp

Just before dawn, Serath tells you three things about the Blue Wing's plans — specific things that can only come from someone recently inside the command structure.

Intelligence Gained: Dragon Army timeline on the north road is two days earlier than garrison estimates. The Blue Wing has orders to take Vogler before moving to Kalaman.

A) Thank them formally. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 53
B) Ask what they want in return. 'Nothing,' they say. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 53

SCENE 51 — MOVING THE COLUMN

South Road

You get everyone moving. Aldric takes the rear. You take point. Three miles north you hear the patrol behind you.

COMBAT ENCOUNTER — REARGUARD ACTION

Hold 3 Baaz Draconians and 1 Human Corporal for 3 rounds while refugees move ahead.

ENEMIES:

• Baaz Draconian x3: AC 13, HP 18 each.

• Human Soldier (Corporal): AC 14, HP 16. Longsword +4 1d8+2. Tactical Command: one draconian gets +2 to its next attack.

Enemy Tactics: Corporal hangs back with crossbow. After 3 rounds a recall horn sounds.

Rewards: 20 XP. Column is clear.

Fallen (0 HP): Column is safe. Aldric stabilised you. 1 HP, one exhaustion.

A) Proceed to Scene 53. --> Scene 53

SCENE 52 — THE DEFENSIVE POSITION

Waystation

You organise the waystation into a defensible position. The patrol probes twice and pulls back.

Outcome: Refugees safe. You take 1d6 damage (roll or take 3). +2 SWORD.

A) Proceed to Scene 53. --> Scene 53
D) Paladin: before continuing, turn to Scene P2. --> Scene P2

End of Act Two.

PALADIN SCENE P2 — THE CHAPEL VISION

Castle Brightholm — Old Chapel, Night

PALADIN ONLY

This scene occurs the night before the formal Trials begin. Fighters: proceed directly to Scene 53 after Scene 51 or 52.

You cannot sleep. The old chapel of the garrison is not the official chapel — the official one is clean and regularly used. This one is behind the armoury, half the roof gone, grass growing through the floor stones. The garrison uses it for storage now. But the altar is still there, uncovered, and the stone that was once the offering bowl is still the shape of a bowl.

You did not mean to come here. You were walking and ended up here. That is different from choosing.

You sit in front of the altar for a while. Nothing happens. Then you put your hand in the offering bowl — an absurd thing to do, and you do not know why you do it — and the stone is warm. Not the warmth of stone that has been sitting in an enclosed space. Warm like something living.

DIVINE SIGN

The warmth travels up your arm and settles behind your sternum. Not painful. Not frightening. It feels like: the moment before you speak the correct answer to something important. Certainty that has not yet found words. The stone is warm and the grass is still growing through the floor and the stars are visible through the broken roof and you understand, in the part of you below language, that you are not alone in this room.

You speak aloud. You have not decided to do this — it simply happens. You say: 'Who are you?' No answer in words. But the warmth in your chest becomes, briefly, the specific warmth of something smiling. Then it fades to ordinary stone temperature and you are alone again.

You think about what kind of warmth that was:

PALADINE	KIRI-JOLITH	MISHAKAL	HABBAKUK	BRANCHALA
Signs: ___	Signs: ___	Signs: ___	Signs: ___	Signs: ___

A) The warmth of law and order — a gentle judge's certainty, high and patient. Mark 1 tally: PALADINE. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 53

B) The warmth of a forge before battle — practical, purposeful, directed. Mark 1 tally: KIRI-JOLITH. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 53

C) The warmth of a healer's hands — soft, focused on what hurts. Mark 1 tally: MISHAKAL. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 53

D) The warmth of sunlight through trees — wide, un-directed, alive. Mark 1 tally: HABBAKUK. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 53

E) The warmth of music heard from another room — joyful, reaching, optimistic. Mark 1 tally: BRANCHALA. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 53

F) You cannot read it. The warmth was just warmth. Mark nothing. (+1 CROWN for not assuming you understand what you do not yet understand.) --> Scene 53

ACT THREE: THE ROAD NARROWS (LEVEL 2)

Act Three Overview

The Dragon Army is confirmed within twenty miles. The formal Trials are accelerated. Scenes 53-70 cover the crisis, the condensed Trials, and the road south to Vogler. You gain Level 3 at Scene 61. Paladins: Paladin Scene P3 is in Act Three.

SCENE 53 — THE NEWS ARRIVES

Castle Brightholm — Great Hall, Night

Three bells at midnight — the signal everyone knows and hopes never to hear at this hour. The rider is at the back being given water. Lord Caeron is at the front with the dispatch. He reads it through twice. In the moment before he turns, before he chooses his expression, you see what is underneath it. Then he turns. 'The Dragon Army's Blue Wing has been confirmed south of Lake Akh-Tiel. Approximately two thousand. Moving north. Three days from Vogler. Possibly two.'

OPTIONAL ROLL: Composure (WIS Save) (+1) | WIS | DC 11
SUCCESS (roll 11+): Your face stays neutral. Caeron holds your gaze a half-second longer. +1 CROWN.
FAILURE (roll 1-10): Something crosses your expression. No penalty, but it was seen.

A) Go to your companions. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 54
B) Stay for the full briefing. (+1 CROWN) --> Scene 55
C) Find Thessaly. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 56
D) Find Aldric. (+1 ROSE, ROMANCE FLAME Aldric if Spark) --> Scene 57
E) Something is wrong about the timing. Find out who knew first. (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN) --> Scene 53B
F) Find Tariel, if present. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 53D
G) Find Lysander, if present. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 53E

SCENE 53B — THE SOURCE

Castle Brightholm — Records Room, Night After the News

Thessaly finds you an hour after Caeron's briefing. She has been in the records room and her face has the specific quality it gets when she has found something she did not want to find.

The Dragon Army knew the refugees were on the south road before the patrol found them. The dispatch pouch from the patrol — if you kept it — contains a reference code that matches a garrison communication cipher. The Blue Wing had intelligence on the garrison's movements. Current intelligence. Not intercepted — given.

Thessaly lays it out carefully: the timing, the cipher reference, the two officers who had access to that level of communication. One is dead — killed in the ambush on the south road. The other is Ser Aldous.

> *DARK SCENE — BETRAYAL*
>
> Ser Aldous, who told you about the village he could not save. Who mentored you on the Measure. Thessaly's evidence is circumstantial but strong. What you do with this is yours to decide. Caeron does not know yet.

There is another possibility Thessaly offers, quietly: the cipher reference could have been planted to implicate Aldous. By the Dragon Army, if they knew his history with that village. If someone wanted a trusted garrison mentor removed. She does not know which is true. She has given you everything she has.

> **ROLL REQUIRED:** Investigation (INT, proficiency if trained) (+3) | INT | DC 14
>
> **SUCCESS (roll 14+):** The cipher reference uses a secondary field code, not the primary garrison cipher. A traitor using the primary code would be caught by standard security sweeps. Using the secondary requires counter-intelligence knowledge — this narrows the suspect list significantly and rules out the obvious names.
>
> **FAILURE (roll 1-13):** The evidence is what Thessaly described. You cannot evaluate it further without more information.
>
> *No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail*

> **A) Take the evidence to Lord Caeron immediately. Let the command structure decide. (+2 CROWN. Aldous is investigated. If guilty, imprisoned. If framed, exonerated — but the investigation takes two weeks the garrison does not have.) --> Scene 54**
>
> **B) Confront Aldous directly, alone, before going to Caeron. Give him the chance to explain. (+2 ROSE — this could go very badly.) --> Scene 53C**
>
> **C) Tell no one yet. Keep it between you and Thessaly and watch Aldous closely. (+1 ROSE, +1 SWORD — dangerous. But if he is innocent, you have protected him.) --> Scene 54**
>
> **D) Destroy the evidence. Aldous has given you too much for this to be what it looks like. (+1 ROSE — this is also a moral failure. You may be wrong.) --> Scene 54**

SCENE 53C — ALDOUS ALONE

Castle Brightholm — Chapel Steps, Night

He is exactly where he always is late at night: the chapel steps, watching whatever hawk or star he watches when he cannot sleep. He sees you coming and he looks at what you are carrying — the papers — and something in his face shifts. Not guilt. Something more complicated.

He is quiet for a long time after you show him. Then: 'I did not give them information about the refugees. I would tell you if I had. I have been honest with you about worse things than this.' He looks at the cipher reference. 'I

know who used this code. And I know who had reason to make it look like me.'

He gives you a name. A garrison officer you know slightly — someone whose brother is a Dragon Army officer. Someone who has been sending private correspondence south. Someone Aldous has been watching for three weeks and has not yet had enough evidence to bring to Caeron.

> *The Real Traitor*
>
> Aldous was right. The officer is the source. If you went to Aldous first, you now have the actual name. You can bring this to Caeron with full context — but it means admitting you sat on Thessaly's evidence for a night before reporting it. Caeron will know. He will not say anything. He will remember.

> **A) Take everything to Caeron immediately — Thessaly's evidence, Aldous's name, all of it. (+2 ROSE, +1 CROWN. The traitor is caught. Aldous is cleared. Caeron gives you a look that means: you handled that correctly even if imperfectly.) --> Scene 54**
>
> **B) Deal with the officer yourself, tonight, before Caeron is involved. (+1 SWORD — dangerous, legally questionable. But fast. The garrison is not compromised further.) --> Scene 54**

SCENE 53D — TARIEL AFTER THE NEWS

Castle Brightholm — Map Room, Night (Conditional: Tariel in party)

'Two thousand soldiers,' she says. 'Moving north. The garrison has — what — eighty? The decree sent thirty refugees south into their path. And the Order's response is to accelerate your Trials so you can ride to Vogler as a sworn squire rather than an unsworn one.' She looks at you. 'Does the title make your sword sharper?'

Then she opens the locket. A portrait. A young man in Dragon Army colours. Dark hair like hers. Her eyes.

'My brother,' she says. 'Aldren. He joined the Dragon Army because the Knights would not have him — wrong province, wrong politics, wrong family name. He tried to leave after Thresh. They do not let people leave. He is dead. Both institutions failed him. He was twenty-three.'

> **OPTIONAL ROLL:** Insight (+1) | WIS | DC 13
>
> **SUCCESS (roll 13+):** The locket portrait is recent. The grief is not old. The diplomatic observer role is a response. She is not your enemy. She is something more complicated.
>
> **FAILURE (roll 1-12):** She is grieving. The arguments are a form of grief.

CONVICTION CHOICE (Tariel Corruption Track — Debate 2):

A) 'Neither system killed your brother. People did. The Measure exists to hold those people accountable.' (CONVICTION: remains or improves toward STEADFAST. +1 CROWN.) --> Scene 54

B) 'I am sorry about Aldren. The Order should have been better. I intend to make it better.' (CONVICTION: remains. +1 ROSE.) --> Scene 54

C) 'You are right. Both systems failed. I do not know what replaces them but I know they are not enough.' (CONVICTION: advances toward FALLEN. +1 ROSE, -1 CROWN.) --> Scene 54

D) 'The Order can be reformed. Your brother's death is an argument for reform, not abandonment.' (CONVICTION: improves toward STEADFAST. +2 CROWN.) --> Scene 54

ROMANCE CHOICE (optional — if at SPARK or higher):

R1) 'I am sorry about Aldren.' Name him. Touch her hand. (ROMANCE FLAME Tariel)

R2) Maintain professional distance. (Romance holds.)

SCENE 53E — LYSANDER'S TRUTH

Castle Brightholm — Garrison Wall, Night (Conditional: Lysander in party)

He tells you. The bridge. The refugees. The court-martial. The Knight who filed the court-martial was promoted to Commander.

He tells this story the way Aldous told his — flat, worn smooth. But where Aldous carries the weight as penance, Lysander carries it as evidence.

CONVICTION CHOICE (Lysander Corruption Track — Experience 3):

A) 'File the appeal. I will speak on your behalf.' (CONVICTION: improves toward STEADFAST. +1 ROSE, +1 CROWN.) --> Scene 54

B) 'The system that punished you is broken. It needs people like you inside it.' (CONVICTION: remains. +1 CROWN.) --> Scene 54

C) 'They promoted the man who let people drown. I do not know how to defend that.' (CONVICTION: advances toward FALLEN. +1 ROSE, -1 CROWN.) --> Scene 54

D) 'You did the right thing. The institution did the wrong thing. Both are true and I can hold both.' (CONVICTION: QUESTIONING. +2 ROSE.) --> Scene 54

E) 'I want to believe the Order would have done differently if it knew.' (CONVICTION: SHAKEN. +1 ROSE. -1 to highest Order tally.) --> Scene 54

ROMANCE CHOICE (optional — if at SPARK or higher):

R1) Put your hand on his arm. (ROMANCE FLAME Lysander)

R2) Carry it with him through witness. (Romance holds.)

SCENE 54 — TENDING THE COMPANIONS

Castle Brightholm

Aldric is in the armoury, re-checking equipment. Mira — if present — is doubling her medical supplies. Serath — if present — is watching the south road.

A) Spend the time with Aldric. (+1 SWORD, ROMANCE FLAME Aldric if Spark) --> Scene 60
B) Spend the time with Mira if present, otherwise train. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 60
C) Sit with Serath if present. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 60

SCENE 54B — MIRA TENDS SERATH

Castle Brightholm — Infirmary, Night (NPC Cross-Talk — Conditional: both Mira and Serath present)

You pass the infirmary and the door is ajar. Inside: Mira is re-dressing Serath's wound. Her hands move with certainty. She does not look at Serath's face while she works.

Serath is watching Mira's hands. Then the assessment becomes something else. They are watching someone who is kind to them without asking for anything.

Mira: 'What you did — leaving the army. That took a different kind of courage.' Serath: 'You are the first person who called it courage.'

A) Watch. Learn. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 60
B) Enter. 'Is there anything you need?' (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 60

SCENE 55 — THE EMPTY HALL

Castle Brightholm — Great Hall

Everyone left. The hall emptied in the efficient way of a military institution responding to something real. You stayed. You are not entirely sure why — something in how he stood after everyone else left made going feel like the wrong thing to do. He is at the table now with the dispatch open again, reading it a third time or using it as somewhere to look. He hears you. Looks up. For one moment, before the composure reassembles, you see what is underneath the officer. He is thirty years old. He is afraid. He is very good at his job and that has not made this less frightening. 'You stayed,' he says. The two words carry at least three others.

ROMANCE MOMENT

'I intend to conduct your Trials evaluation before we march — whatever comes after, you should have the thing you came here for.' He says this to his papers. You have never heard Caeron Ashvale ask for anything before.

You stay for a while. Not long — there is work to do and both of you know it. But a while. The dispatch is still open on the table. He does not close it. You do not ask him to. Some things you can only do if you do not make them into an act — if you just stand in the same room with someone who is carrying something heavy until they are ready to carry it into the next room.

A) 'I do. Thank you, my lord.' (+2 CROWN, ROMANCE FLAME Caeron if Spark) --> Scene 60

B) 'What about you? What do you want?' (+2 ROSE, Caeron goes very still) --> Scene 59

C) Stand beside him at the table. Look at the dispatch together. Say nothing. (+2 ROSE, ROMANCE FLAME Caeron) --> Scene 59

SCENE 56 — THESSALY'S INFORMATION

Castle Brightholm

Thessaly finds you in the map room an hour after the briefing. She has been busy since — ink on her hands, the look of someone who has been writing fast and stopping to think. She lays it out: the Dragon Army has a specific objective in Vogler. Not only the supply route. Something in the village — or someone. She has narrowed it to two possibilities and cannot narrow it further. 'I wanted you to know before we march,' she says. 'Because you are riding toward it whether you know what it is or not.'

OPTIONAL ROLL: History (INT, proficiency if trained) (+3) | INT | DC 13

SUCCESS (roll 13+): Vogler is on Lake Akh-Tiel — the only navigable route between the southern Solamnic coast and the northern fortresses that does not require mountain passes. Whoever controls Vogler controls that supply line for the whole northern campaign. The Dragon Army does not need something in the village. They need the village itself.

FAILURE (roll 1-12): The strategic value is military. You cannot narrow it further.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

A) Take this to Caeron immediately. (+1 CROWN, +1 ROSE) --> Scene 60

B) Keep it between you for now. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 60

SCENE 57 — ALDRIC IN THE ARMOURY

Castle Brightholm

He is sharpening his sword for the third time tonight. You can tell it is the third time because the blade has the particular high shine of something worked past the point of usefulness by someone who needed something to do with their hands. He looks up when he hears you.

The armoury is quiet. Tallow candles, low. Somewhere down the corridor someone is walking fast and then stopping, then fast again — the sound of a garrison trying to be ready for something it cannot fully prepare for. After a while Aldric sets the whetstone down. 'Whatever Order claims you,' he says, 'I am glad you were here this year.'

ROMANCE MOMENT

He hands you a leather wrist guard — his, slightly worn. 'Fits better than yours,' he says. He is not looking at you.

CONDITIONAL — IF YOU READ SCENE 53B CHOICE B

If in Scene 53B you chose option B (implicating Aldric): before your choice below, turn to Scene 58B (What Aldric Did) now.

A) Take it. 'Thank you.' (+2 ROSE, ROMANCE FLAME Aldric if Spark active) --> Scene 60

B) 'You will want it back when this is over.' 'Maybe,' he says. (+1 ROSE, +1 SWORD) --> Scene 60

SCENE 58B — WHAT ALDRIC DID

Castle Brightholm — Storeroom, Night Before Trials

CONDITIONAL DARK SCENE

This scene occurs if Aldric is in your party AND you chose Option B in Scene 53B (watched the suspected traitor rather than reporting).

Aldric finds you before you find him. He looks like someone who has done something and cannot undo it and has not decided yet whether he should try.

He found the officer. The one Aldous named. He followed him to the storeroom where the private correspondence was hidden. And then — Aldric does not describe this part clearly, and you do not push him — something happened. The officer is alive. He is going to stay alive. He is also, currently, unconscious, bound, and in the storeroom, and Aldric hit him harder than he meant to and then harder than that and then stopped himself and he does not know what to do with what stopping himself felt like.

He looks at you. He is not asking for absolution. He is asking whether he is still the person he thought he was. He does not know yet. He wants you to help him figure it out.

MORAL WEIGHT

Aldric did not kill him. He stopped. That matters. But he also crossed a line the Measure is very clear about. The officer is a traitor. Aldric's anger was not wrong. His method was. Both of these are true at the same time.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Medicine (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | WIS | DC 12

SUCCESS (roll 12+): His knuckles are split and his breathing is slightly elevated — not from exertion but from the controlled effort of not shaking. He stopped himself mid-action. That kind of stop leaves a specific mark: not guilt about what he did but the physical memory of choosing not to continue. He is more in control of himself than he believes. Tell him this.

FAILURE (roll 1-11): He is in distress. The specific detail of his emotional state is not readable.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

A) Report everything to Caeron — the officer, Aldric's actions, all of it. Aldric faces a formal reprimand. The traitor is imprisoned. (+2 CROWN. Aldric looks at you with something complicated. He would have done the same. He respects this. It still costs something.) --> Scene 60

B) Report the officer. Say Aldric found him and subdued him in the line of duty. The rest is not said. (+1 SWORD — this is a lie. You will both know that. Aldric owes you one. So do you.) --> Scene 60

C) Tell Aldric: 'You stopped. That is the part that matters.' Then go wake Caeron together. (+2 ROSE — this is the hardest choice. It does not protect either of you. It is honest.) --> Scene 60

SCENE 59 — WHAT CAERON CANNOT SAY

Castle Brightholm — Great Hall

'I became a knight because the world requires people willing to stand in front of the bad things. I have been wondering for some time whether I am still that person.' A pause. 'You make me think that I might be.'

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | WIS | DC 15

SUCCESS (roll 15+): He said 'still' — present tense. This is not a past doubt: it is active. Lord Caeron Ashvale does not know if he has what this moment requires. He told you because he trusts you with it. ROMANCE FLAME Caeron activates immediately if you respond without trying to reassure him.

FAILURE (roll 1-14): He is speaking honestly but opaquely. The layer beneath the words is not clear.

No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

A) 'You are.' (+2 ROSE, ROMANCE FLAME Caeron) --> Scene 60

B) 'Show me at Vogler.' (+1 ROSE, +1 SWORD, Caeron looks at you steadily) --> Scene 60

C) Paladin: something pulls you to the south field tonight. Turn to Scene P3 (The Test) before Scene 60. --> Scene P3

SCENE 60 — THE ACCELERATED TRIALS

Castle Brightholm — Great Hall, Dawn

The day of the Trials begins before dawn. No ceremony — there is no time for it. But someone has lit the chapel candles anyway, all of them, and left them burning without explanation.

Stripped of the usual ritual, the day has a different weight — denser, more honest. Physical evaluation. Combat assessment, Aldric as your opponent. Written Measure examination. An oral panel: Caeron, Aldous, and two senior knights whose names you have never learned because they have been here for thirty years and no longer need names so much as presence.

> ***IF SERA IS IN YOUR PARTY:*** *Sera is not in the hall for the Trials — she is on the armoury roof again, where she was the first time you saw her. She watches the sparring bout from above. After, when you pass the armoury, there is a folded note on the step: 'Your footwork gap is fixed. Your guard on the right needs work. I will show you on the road. — S.' This is the most she has ever written to you.*

ROLL REQUIRED: Athletics (Sparring Bout) (+3) | STR | DC 15
SUCCESS (roll 15+): You disarm Aldric on the third pass. +2 SWORD. The panel leans forward.
FAILURE (roll 1-14): Aldric takes the bout. +1 SWORD — they evaluate effort, not only outcome.
No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

ROLL REQUIRED: History / Religion (Written Measure Exam) (+0) | INT | DC 14
SUCCESS (roll 14+): Your responses are precise and occasionally surprising. Aldous underlines one answer twice. +2 ROSE. (Paladins: your answer on divine duty is unexpectedly sophisticated.)
FAILURE (roll 1-13): Solid, correct, conventional. +1 ROSE.
No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = pass | Tails = fail

Final Oral Question:

'Name the highest principle of the Solamnic Knighthood.'

A) 'Est Sularus oth Mithas. My honour is my life.' (+2 CROWN) --> Scene 61
B) 'The protection of the innocent, from which all other laws derive.' (+3 ROSE) --> Scene 61
C) 'Courage in the face of darkness, maintained even when the outcome is uncertain.' (+2 SWORD) --> Scene 61

TONIGHT — BEFORE SCENE 61

The Oath is tomorrow. Tonight is the last night before everything changes. • PALADINS on the DG track: turn to Scene DG3 (The Crown) now. • FIGHTERS on the Measure track: turn to Scene M3 (Two Oaths) now. M3 leads to M4, then return to Scene 62.

PALADIN SCENE P3 — THE TEST

Castle Brightholm — South Field, Night Before Trials

> *PALADIN ONLY*
> Fighters: proceed directly to Scene 60.

The south field is empty and dark. You are here because something pulled you — the same wordless pull that brought you to the old chapel. You are getting used to following it. You are not sure this is wise.

There is a figure in the field. Not human — or not entirely. It has the general shape of a person standing very still in the darkness, but the details do not resolve cleanly. It does not threaten. It waits.

It speaks. One question. Simple. Unanswerable by anyone who has not thought about it very carefully:

> *DIVINE SIGN*
> 'You have power that most people in this age do not possess. It came to you through something vast and old that has been watching you since before you knew it was there. The question is not whether you will use it. You will. The question is: for whom?'

The figure waits. It is genuinely asking. This is not a test with a wrong answer — it is a test to see if you have an answer at all, and whether it is yours.

> **A) 'For the innocent. For those who cannot protect themselves.' Mark 1 tally: PALADINE or MISHAKAL (your choice). (+2 ROSE) --> Scene P3a**
> **B) 'For those who fight beside me. For the line that holds.' Mark 1 tally: KIRI-JOLITH. (+2 SWORD) --> Scene P3b**
> **C) 'For the living things that have no voice in the decisions made about them.' Mark 1 tally: HABBAKUK. (+1 ROSE, +1 SWORD) --> Scene P3c**
> **D) 'For the possibility that the world can be better than it is.' Mark 1 tally: BRANCHALA or PALADINE (your choice). (+2 ROSE) --> Scene P3d**
> **E) 'I do not know yet. I am still becoming the person who will know.' Mark nothing. (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN) --> Scene P3e**

PALADIN SCENE P3a — THE TEST — RESPONSE

The figure is still for a long time. Then: 'Good. That answer holds.' It does not say whose answer it is. It does not need to. It was already there when you started speaking.

Award: +2 ROSE. Proceed to Scene 60.

PALADIN SCENE P3b — THE TEST — RESPONSE

The figure's stillness changes quality — something in it settles, like a weapon lowered rather than sheathed. 'That is the answer of a soldier. There is no higher one.' It steps back and is not there anymore.

Award: +2 SWORD. Proceed to Scene 60.

PALADIN SCENE P3c — THE TEST — RESPONSE

The figure turns its head as if listening to something you cannot hear. Then: 'There are more things alive in this world than have names. It is good to remember them.' Warmth. Brief. Gone.

Award: +1 ROSE +1 SWORD. Proceed to Scene 60.

PALADIN SCENE P3d — THE TEST — RESPONSE

The figure makes a sound that might be music if it were louder. 'That is the most difficult answer,' it says. 'It requires you to keep hoping.' A pause. 'Do not stop.'

Award: +2 ROSE. Proceed to Scene 60.

PALADIN SCENE P3e — THE TEST — RESPONSE

The figure is still for a long time. Then, quietly: 'Most people never ask the question. You asked it. That is enough for now.' It is gone when you blink.

Award: +1 ROSE +1 CROWN. Proceed to Scene 60.

SCENE DG3 — THE CROWN

Castle Brightholm — Night Before the Oath (Paladin Only)

> *PALADIN ONLY*
> Only triggers if you are LISTENING, COMPROMISED, or FALLEN on the DG track. If you are HELD FIRM throughout: skip to Scene 61 — you will receive your gift there instead.

You are alone in the old chapel. The official ceremony is tomorrow. You have been sitting here for an hour with your hands on your knees trying to remember why you started. The voice does not whisper tonight. It speaks

clearly, quietly, with the tone of someone who believes they are offering something genuinely good.

> *DARK TEMPTATION — TAKHISIS SPEAKS PLAINLY*
>
> Tomorrow they give you an Order. Rose, Sword, Crown — their little hierarchy of virtue. I offer you something they cannot. Not a rank. A purpose. The Dragon Armies will reshape this world. Every Solamnic Knight who rides against them will die for a structure that cannot hold. But a Knight who rides with me — a Knight who carries both edges — could change everything. Not a traitor. A bridge. You know how to hold two truths. I am asking you to hold this one: the light and the dark, working through the same hands.

This is the most sophisticated temptation yet. It is not asking you to be evil. It is asking you to believe the ends justify the means and that you are wise enough to navigate the result. It might even be true. That is what makes it the worst one.

> **A) No. The oath is not a strategy. It is what you are. (+3 DG: PURIFIED — proceed to DG3_purified) --> Scene DG3_purified**
>
> **B) You are tempted — but you pull back. You spend the night in prayer. (COMPROMISED → LISTENING, LISTENING → HELD, costs you sleep: -2 HP max until long rest) --> Scene DG3_resist**
>
> **C) You accept. The bridge metaphor is genuinely compelling. (FALLEN — proceed to DG3_fall) --> Scene DG3_fall**

SCENE DG3_purified — THE PURIFICATION

Castle Brightholm — Old Chapel, Night Before the Oath

You say no so clearly that the voice does not just leave — something cleanses. Whatever had been accumulating — the listening, the delay, the compromise — burns off in a single moment of absolute certainty. You know who you are. You know whose you are. Tomorrow the Oath will be the truest thing you have ever said.

> *DG TRACK: PURIFIED ✓✓*
>
> All previous compromises cleared. Restore any reduced Lay on Hands pool. Restore frozen god tallies — add +1 to highest for this proof of faith. Proceed to DG_GIFT_PURE for your reward.

> **A) Receive your gift. --> Scene DG_GIFT_PURE**

SCENE DG3_resist — THE HARD RETREAT

Castle Brightholm — Old Chapel, Night Before the Oath

You pull back. It costs you — not just sleep. The cost is the admission that you were closer than you want to admit. You spend the night in prayer with the specific discomfort of someone who has seen themselves clearly and does not entirely like the view. By morning you are steady. Not clean — steady. That distinction matters. Steady is enough.

DG TRACK: PULLED BACK ✓

Improved state. Lay on Hands partially restored (+2 to pool). God tallies partially unfrozen. Proceed to DG_GIFT_SCARRED for your reward.

A) Receive your gift. --> Scene DG_GIFT_SCARRED

SCENE DG3_fall — THE BRIDGE ACCEPTED

Castle Brightholm — Old Chapel, Night Before the Oath

You have convinced yourself. That is the part that will haunt you later — not that you were deceived but that you did the work yourself. The reasoning was so good. In the morning you take the Oath with the others. The words come out. They feel true. They feel true through something. Through something that is not quite you anymore.

DG TRACK: DEEPLY FALLEN ■■■■

The Oath is taken. Its power continues to function. The source is no longer what you believe it is. • Lay on Hands heals 1 HP per use until DG4 is resolved. • Divine Smite functions. The radiance is violet-tinged. • Proceed to DG4 — The Reckoning is your next scene on the road to Vogler.

A) Continue to Scene 61. --> Scene 61

SCENE DG_GIFT_PURE — THE GIFT OF STEADFAST FAITH

Castle Brightholm — After the Oath Ceremony

After the ceremony, after everyone else has gone, you find something on the chapel step. It was not there when you arrived. There is no note. You do not need one. The warmth in it is unmistakeable — the same warmth from P1, the same quality, made solid and given form. Your god has been watching. Your god is pleased.

✦ *MAGIC ITEM GAINED: THE UNBROKEN VOW*

Wondrous Item (Requires Attunement by a Paladin), Uncommon

A silver disc engraved with the words EST SULARUS OTH MITHAS on one side and a five-pointed star on the other. It is warm to the touch and has been since you found it.

Mechanics: While attuned: your Lay on Hands pool increases by 5 HP. Once per long rest: when you or an ally within 10 ft. drops to 0 HP, you may use your reaction to immediately stabilise them and grant them 1 HP. Additionally, you have advantage on saving throws against fear effects.

Lore: Given to a paladin who was tempted and did not bend.

✦ *MAGIC ITEM GAINED: OATH-KEEPER*

Weapon (Longsword), Requires Attunement by a Paladin, Rare

A longsword with a blade of white steel and a crossguard shaped like two wings folded in rest. The grip is wrapped in white leather that does not soil. The blade catches light and holds it a moment longer than it should.

Mechanics: +1 bonus to attack and damage rolls. When you hit a fiend or undead, the target takes an extra 1d6 radiant damage. Once per long rest: on a hit, you may choose to maximise the damage rather than rolling. The sword does not glow on command — it glows when it judges the moment worthy.

Lore: Forged in spirit and given form by an act of unbroken faith. In the main campaign, it will glow in the presence of Dragon Army officers who are genuinely conflicted about their service.

✦ *MAGIC ITEM GAINED: THE VIGIL CLOAK*

Wondrous Item (Cloak), Requires Attunement by a Paladin or Knight, Rare

A deep blue-grey cloak with a silver clasp shaped like the Solamnic sun. It is heavier than it looks and does not blow in wind.

Mechanics: +1 to AC. Advantage on saving throws against being magically moved or knocked prone. Once per long rest: when an ally within 30 ft. is targeted by an attack, you may use your reaction to impose disadvantage on that attack roll. Cannot be charmed or frightened while in direct sunlight.

Lore: Given to a paladin who stood where they were supposed to stand and did not move.

A) Continue to Scene 62. --> Scene 62

SCENE DG_GIFT_SCARRED — THE GIFT OF THE SCARRED FLAME

Castle Brightholm or Vogler Road — After Pulling Back

You do not find it placed with ceremony. It is simply in your hand at some point after — after the hard night of prayer, after the slow return. You are not entirely sure when it arrived.

✦ MAGIC ITEM GAINED: THE SCARRED FLAME

Wondrous Item (Requires Attunement by a Paladin), Uncommon

A pendant shaped like a flame with a crack through it, sealed with silver. The gold and violet in the metalwork are both deliberately visible — not hidden, acknowledged.

Mechanics: Once per long rest: when you fail a saving throw against a charm or compulsion effect, you may reroll it with advantage. Proficiency in Insight checks when determining if a creature is deceiving you or acting under magical influence. Your Lay on Hands pool is fully restored.

Lore: Given to a paladin who was tempted, bent toward the fall, and pulled back. The scar is not hidden because the gods of good do not hide their histories.

A) Proceed to Scene 62. --> Scene 62

SCENE M3 — TWO OATHS

Castle Brightholm — Night of the Oath Ceremony (Fighter Only)

FIGHTER ONLY

This scene occurs on the night of Scene 61, after the ceremony. Paladins skip to Scene 62.

After the ceremony, after Caeron's sword and the words and Aldous in the corner, you find yourself standing outside the chapel with a very specific question you did not have before you took the oath. The oath says: honour the innocent, obey your commanding officer, serve the Order. But you have now seen, in three weeks of field exercise, two cases where those clauses are in direct conflict. Aldous finds you. Of course he does. 'You have questions,' he says. Not a question.

THE MEASURE: THE MEASURE ON CONFLICTING OBLIGATIONS

The Oath has three pillars: Rose (justice, compassion, wisdom), Sword (courage, battle, honour), Crown (law, loyalty, duty). The Measure does not rank them. This is intentional. It places the burden of adjudication on the Knight who must live with both the choice and its consequences.

A) 'When the three conflict, Rose takes precedence. A law that creates injustice has already broken the Oath.' (+3 MEASURE TRACK. ROSE orientation) --> Scene M3_rose

B) 'When the three conflict, Sword takes precedence — the person who holds the line protects the others.' (+3 MEASURE TRACK. SWORD orientation) --> Scene M3_sword

C) 'When the three conflict, Crown takes precedence — the structure must hold or nothing else can.' (+3 MEASURE TRACK. CROWN orientation) --> Scene M3_crown

D) 'I do not know yet. I think the answer is situational.' (+2 MEASURE TRACK. BALANCE orientation) --> Scene M3_balance

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SCENE M3_rose — THE ROSE PATH

Chapel Yard

Aldous looks at you steadily. 'The Rose Knights have always said that. Most of them are right. Some of them have used it to excuse breaking every rule they found inconvenient. The difference is whether you actually know what justice requires or whether you just think you do.' A pause. 'You do. So far.'

MEASURE TRACK: ROSE orientation.

A) Continue to Scene M4. --> Scene M4

SCENE M3_sword — THE SWORD PATH

Chapel Yard

Aldous considers this. 'The Sword Knights have always said that too. And they are right: the person who does not hold their post creates the hole that everything else falls through. The question is what you do when holding your post requires injustice.' He looks at you. 'You have an answer. I can tell.'

MEASURE TRACK: SWORD orientation.

A) Continue to Scene M4. --> Scene M4

SCENE M3_crown — THE CROWN PATH

Chapel Yard

'The Crown Knights,' Aldous says. 'The institution has to survive for the ideal to survive — that argument has defended both the best decisions and the worst ones in Solamnic history. The difference is who is doing the reforming and from what motive.' He is quiet. 'You have the motive right. Keep it.'

> *MEASURE TRACK: CROWN orientation.*

> **A) Continue to Scene M4. --> Scene M4**

SCENE M3_balance — THE BALANCE PATH

Chapel Yard

Aldous is quiet for a long time. Then: 'That is the answer the Measure itself gives, if you read it carefully. The lack of ranking is intentional. It is asking every Knight to do the hardest thing: think. Every time. Even when you are tired.' He nods. 'Harder path. But a real one.'

> *MEASURE TRACK: BALANCE orientation.*

> **A) Continue to Scene M4. --> Scene M4**

SCENE 61 — THE OATH OF SQUIREHOOD

Castle Brightholm — Chapel, Afternoon

Caeron's sword is cold on your shoulder. The chapel smells of tallow and old stone and something you will later identify as the specific smell of commitment taking a permanent form. Aldric in the front row, jaw set. Thessaly with her notebook closed. Mira at the back if she is still here. Ser Aldous in the corner.

Caeron speaks the words of the Oath of Squirehood. When you rise, quiet enough for only you: 'Whatever Order claims you — you have earned this.'

> *You Are Now a Squire*
> Total your Order points. The highest score determines which Order claims your oath.

LEVEL UP — YOU ARE NOW LEVEL 3

Fighter Level 3: Full Archetype activates. Paladin Level 3: Sacred Oath (Devotion, Ancients, or Vengeance). Channel Divinity: 2 uses/long rest. Spell slots increase to 3 first-level.

Native PC — Fighter: HP +7 (total 26). Paladin: HP +6 (total 22).

ITEM GIVEN — ALDOUS'S COMPASS

A small brass compass, old, with a chip on the case. 'It has been wrong since 862,' he says. 'Points about twelve degrees west of north. I have used it my entire career and navigated correctly every time, because I knew to account for it.'

End of Act Three.

ACT FOUR: THE ROAD TO VOGLER (LEVEL 3)

Act Four Overview

You march south toward Vogler. Two more combat encounters await. Romance arcs reach their Oath moments. Paladins: Paladin Scene P4 — the Choosing — is in Act Four.

SCENE 62 — THE MARCH

South Road — Day 1

Brightholm disappears behind the first hill at the third mile. You watch the towers go until the hill takes them. Aldric rides beside you in the grey morning and says nothing, which is something — Aldric Voss does not ride in silence unless he is thinking something he has not yet decided whether to say.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Perception (+2) | WIS | DC 12

SUCCESS (roll 12+): Boot prints south of the verge — someone left the road in a hurry recently. Relevant in Scene 70.

FAILURE (roll 1-11): The road looks clear.

After a long while: 'Whatever Order you got — I am not competing with you anymore.' He means: I will now be competing to be worthy of riding beside you, which is a different thing.

A) Laugh. 'That is the nicest thing you have said to me.' (+1 ROSE, ROMANCE FLAME Aldric) --> Scene 62D

B) 'Understood. Same.' Comfortable silence. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 62D

C) 'Race you to the ridge.' (+1 SWORD, Aldric grins) --> Scene 62D

SCENE 62D — THE FIRST NIGHT ON THE ROAD

South Road — Day 1, Evening Camp

The first night out of Brightholm is the hardest. Not because of danger — the road is clear for eight miles — but because of what leaving means. The garrison towers were visible until the fifth mile, then the ridge took them. Brightholm is behind you.

Camp is set with garrison efficiency. The fire is regulation size, which means small and purposeful. You eat garrison rations: hard bread, dried meat, a cheese that has survived the march better than expected. Not good food. Adequate food, eaten in the company of people you have spent the most important weeks of your life with, which makes it the best food you have ever eaten.

NPC CROSS-TALK — CAERON AND SERA

At the edge of camp: Lord Caeron is speaking with Sera Nighthollow. Caeron's careful listening posture; Sera's clipped precision. When they finish, Caeron nods once. Sera glances at you briefly. Whatever she told him, it was about the road ahead.

IF TARIEL IS IN YOUR PARTY: *She eats apart from the column. She has her notebook open. Once, she looks up and catches your eye. The moment lasts three seconds. She looks down first.*

IF LYSANDER IS IN YOUR PARTY: *He is not in the camp. He rides parallel, not with, the column. Visible occasionally at the treeline, then not visible.*

A) Walk the perimeter before sleeping. (+1 CROWN) --> Scene 63
B) Find your companions. Sit with them. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 63
C) Watch the stars. Solinari is rising. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 63

SCENE 63 — ALDRIC ON THE ROAD

South Road

'Do you know what I thought when the draconians hit us on the south road? I thought: good, she is here. Or he. Or they.' He glances over once and then back to the road. 'I was glad it was you. Not someone else. Not anyone else.'

A) 'I was glad it was you too.' (+2 ROSE, ROMANCE FLAME Aldric if Spark active) --> Scene 64B
B) 'You fight well.' (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 64B

SCENE 64 — RIDING IN SILENCE

South Road

A good silence — the kind that only exists between people who do not need to fill it. The smoke on the southern horizon is thicker now.

A) Keep the silence all the way to camp. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 64B
B) After a mile, ask him something you have wanted to ask. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 64B

SCENE 64B — THE WAR SIGNS

South Road — Day 2, Morning

The road changes at the tenth mile. The farms are empty — not abandoned, emptied deliberately. At the eleventh mile: a cart on its side, a pair of child's shoes tied together by the laces. At the twelfth mile: a Solamnic mile-marker with fresh chalk. Someone wrote SOUTH NO. Below it, in a different hand: ARMY 2 DAYS.

The column does not comment. The silence deepens.

A) Stop. Pick up the child's shoes. Carry them. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 65
B) Note the chalk for your report. (+1 CROWN, +1 ROSE) --> Scene 65
C) Keep moving. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 65

SCENE 64C — REFUGEES GOING NORTH

South Road — Day 2, Afternoon

Eleven people moving north. You are moving south. The man with the child stops when he sees the tabard. He says: 'Vogler. Please.'

> ***IF YOU SAVED THE REFUGEES IN ACT TWO:*** *One of the eleven recognises you. 'You. You saved us. My daughter is alive because of you.'*
>
> ***IF YOU TURNED THE REFUGEES BACK:*** *You do not know what happened to those thirty people. The not-knowing sits in you like a stone.*

A) Give them your rations. (+2 ROSE) --> Scene 65
B) Brief them on the road north. (+1 ROSE, +1 CROWN) --> Scene 65
C) Keep moving. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 65

SCENE 65 — THE ROAD AMBUSH

South Road — Forest Edge, Day 2

Arrows from the treeline, then three Dragon Army soldiers and a Sivak Draconian Officer. Not a patrol. Assassins. They have a description of Solamnic squire colours. They have found you.

COMBAT ENCOUNTER — DRAGON ARMY ASSASSIN SQUAD

ENEMIES:

• Human Soldier x3: AC 14, HP 14 each. Longsword +4 1d8+2. Crossbow +4 1d8+2.

• Sivak Draconian (Officer): AC 16, HP 48. Greatsword +6 2d6+4. Speed 40 ft., Fly 60 ft.

• Sivak: Shape Steal — on death by melee, takes the killer's appearance. Commander's Aura: soldiers within 30 ft. get +1 to attacks.

IMPORTANT: Do not kill the Sivak in melee — it will Shape Steal your appearance. Use ranged attacks or force it to flee.

Rewards: 50 XP. Sivak carries sealed orders naming you as a specific target.

Fallen (0 HP): Aldric holds the Sivak while you are stabilised. 1 HP, one exhaustion.

A) The ambush is broken. Continue to Scene 66. --> Scene 66

SCENE 66 — AFTER THE AMBUSH

South Road Camp, Night

The sealed orders have your name in them. Caeron looks at this for a long time. 'They know about the dispatch,' he says. 'And about you.' He folds the paper. 'Good — if they are targeting you specifically, that means what you have been doing has mattered enough.'

ROLL REQUIRED: Investigation (+3) | INT | DC 14

SUCCESS (roll 14+): The orders use a standard Blue Wing format except for one line in a different hand containing your specific description. Added by someone with insider access.

FAILURE (roll 1-13): The source of that intelligence is unclear.

A) Keep the information close. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 66B

B) Brief the full command. (+2 CROWN) --> Scene 66B

C) Find Serath — they may be in danger. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 66B

SCENE 66B — CAMP CONVERSATIONS

Forest Road — Day 2, Night Camp

The fire is smaller tonight — Caeron's order. The conversations become the kind that happen in the dark between people aware that remaining conversations may be finite.

Choose one companion to spend the evening with:

A) Aldric. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 66B_Aldric
B) Thessaly. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 66B_Thessaly
C) Mira, if present. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 66B_Mira
D) Serath, if present. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 66B_Serath
E) Caeron. (+1 CROWN) --> Scene 66B_Caeron
F) Tariel, if present. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 66B_Tariel
G) Lysander, if present. (+1 SWORD) --> Scene 66B_Lysander

SCENE 66B_Aldric — WHAT HE CARRIES

He tells you about his mother. She died when he was twelve. 'I compete with you because I do not know another way to tell someone they matter to me. I am working on it. It is slow.'

A) 'I know. I have always known.' (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 67
B) 'You are better at it than you think.' (+1 ROSE, +1 SWORD) --> Scene 67

SCENE 66B_Thessaly — WHAT SHE FEARS

'I am afraid of writing the history that says they fell.' She opens the locket. Inside: a page from a letter her mother wrote the week before the Cataclysm. 'When the world changes, the people who write it down are the ones who decide what it meant.'

A) 'You are. I have seen you work.' (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 67
B) 'Then write the version where we hold.' (+1 SWORD, +1 ROSE) --> Scene 67

SCENE 66B_Mira — WHAT SHE KNOWS

'I know what two thousand soldiers means. In medical terms. I know the arithmetic does not work.' She is not afraid. She is past afraid. 'I will be there anyway.'

A) 'The arithmetic never accounts for the people who refuse to stop.' (+2 ROSE) --> Scene 67
B) Help her count. The counting helps. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 67

SCENE 66B_Serath — WHAT THEY LOST

'I had a unit. Twelve people. When I left, I left them inside. They are in the army marching on Vogler. I may see people I know across the line. I will not hesitate. But I want you to know it costs something.'

A) 'I will stand beside you when it does.' (+1 ROSE, +1 SWORD) --> Scene 67

B) 'If you need to step back, I will cover you.' (+2 ROSE) --> Scene 67

SCENE 66B_Caeron — WHAT HE HIDES

'I have never led people into a situation where I cannot guarantee their survival.' He turns. His face is the face of a man who is thirty years old and does not know if he is enough. 'I wanted someone to know.'

A) 'You are enough. We will hold.' (+2 CROWN, +1 ROSE) --> Scene 67

B) 'Then we hold for as long as we can.' (+1 CROWN, +1 SWORD) --> Scene 67

SCENE 66B_Tariel — THE QUESTION

'If the Oath is what you say it is — why is Vogler undefended? Why were the refugees turned south? Why is a squire being sent where a regiment should be?'

CONVICTION CHOICE (FALLEN is possible here):

A) 'Because the institution is failing does not mean the principle is wrong. I am the principle.' (CONVICTION: STEADFAST. +2 ROSE.) --> Scene 67

B) 'I do not have an answer. I have the Oath and Vogler and the people beside me.' (CONVICTION: QUESTIONING. +1 ROSE, +1 CROWN. Hollow Crown does NOT activate.) --> Scene 67

C) 'You are right. The institution is insufficient. I am taking the Oath anyway because the people at Vogler need someone who shows up.' (CONVICTION: CONVINCED. +2 ROSE, -1 CROWN. HOLLOW CROWN — REDUCED.) --> Scene 67

D) 'The Measure is a beautiful relic. I will carry it because someone should, but I no longer believe it is enough.' (CONVICTION: FALLEN. +1 ROSE, -2 CROWN. HOLLOW CROWN — FULL.) --> Scene 67

E) 'I believe in the Order. I have heard everything you said and I choose this anyway.' (CONVICTION: STEADFAST — strongest. +2 CROWN, +1 ROSE.) --> Scene 67

ROMANCE CHOICE (optional — if at FLAME or higher):

R1) 'Stay. Not for the Order. For me.' (ROMANCE OATH Tariel.)

R2) 'Thank you. For all of it.' (Romance resolves warmly, not Oath.)

R3) Do not address. (Romance fades.)

SCENE 66B_Lysander — THE LAST FIRE

'I took the Oath at nineteen. I meant every word. I stopped meaning them when the system rewarded the decision to let people die and punished the decision to save them, and did both correctly according to its own rules.'

'I am not telling you not to take the Oath. I am telling you: the words are not the thing. You are the thing.'

CONVICTION CHOICE (FALLEN is possible here):

A) 'I will take the Oath. And I will mean it the way you meant it — the real version.' (CONVICTION: CONVINCED. +2 ROSE, -1 CROWN. BROKEN SWORD — REDUCED.) --> Scene 67

B) 'The words are not the thing. The Oath is a formality I will perform because Vogler needs it, not because I believe the institution will save anyone.' (CONVICTION: FALLEN. +1 ROSE, -2 CROWN. BROKEN SWORD — FULL.) --> Scene 67

C) 'The Oath means what I decide it means. What I decide, in the moment, with the people in front of me.' (CONVICTION: QUESTIONING. +1 ROSE, +1 CROWN. Broken Sword does NOT activate.) --> Scene 67

D) 'I hear you. I respect you. And I am going to take the Oath and mean every word because the alternative is a world where no one tries.' (CONVICTION: STEADFAST. +2 CROWN, +1 SWORD.) --> Scene 67

E) 'I do not know what the Oath means yet. I will figure it out after.' (CONVICTION: SHAKEN. +1 ROSE.) --> Scene 67

ROMANCE CHOICE (optional — if at FLAME or higher):

R1) 'Stay with me tonight.' (ROMANCE OATH Lysander. Fade to black.)

R2) Take his hand. Let the fire burn down. (ROMANCE OATH Lysander — quiet.)

R3) 'Thank you.' (Romance resolves warmly, not Oath.)

R4) Do not address. (Romance fades.)

SCENE 67 — ALDRIC AT THE RIVER

Forest River Crossing — Dawn, Day 3

He tells you about three months before you arrived: he disobeyed an order to turn away refugees at the western gate. He has been waiting to be punished. 'I need to know if you would have done the same.'

ROLL REQUIRED: Persuasion (+0) | CHA | DC 13

SUCCESS (roll 13+): +1 Aldric Oath track. ROMANCE OATH activates if Flame was present.

FAILURE (roll 1-12): He nods anyway.

A) 'Yes. I would have done the same.' (+3 ROSE, ROMANCE OATH Aldric) --> Scene 68
B) 'I do not know for certain. But you made the right call.' (+2 ROSE, +1 SWORD) --> Scene 68

SCENE 68 — THE LAST CAMP

Forest Road — Night, Day 3

The last camp before Vogler. Someone has a flute somewhere down the line — playing every night for twenty years. The melody is old. Tomorrow, Vogler.

PALADIN — THE CHOOSING
All Paladins: after your choice below, turn to Scene P4 now.

PALADIN — FALLEN TRACK
If FALLEN on DG track: turn to Scene DG4 now.

FIGHTER — MEASURE TRACK
If you have not yet completed M3 and M4: turn to Scene M3 now.

ROMANCE CONDITIONAL SCENES
If Sera at FLAME: turn to Scene 68B. If Vael at FLAME: turn to Scene 68C.

A) Tell her the true thing. (+2 ROSE, ROMANCE OATH Thessaly if Flame active) --> Scene 69
B) 'Same thing as before. Not being enough.' (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 69
C) 'Right now? Nothing.' (+2 SWORD) --> Scene 69

SCENE 68B — THE LAST CAMP — SERA

Forest Road — Night, Day 3 (if Sera Oath-track active)

CONDITIONAL SCENE
This scene occurs if Sera is at Flame level or above.

The camp is quiet. The watch has changed. Sera is not on rotation tonight — she has not slept in forty hours and you told her you would take the first watch if she told you where she was going. She told you.

You find her at the far edge of the firelight where it thins into darkness, sitting with her back against a tree and her knife across her knees not because she thinks she needs it but because having it there is how she slows down. She looks up at you. The half-dark makes her face different — softer, less defended, the way people look when they think no one is watching.

ROMANCE MOMENT

She says: 'You came.' Like she did not expect it. Like she expected it. Like both are true. You sit down against the same tree and the distance between you is not much. She tilts her head and studies your face with the focused attention she normally gives to terrain. Then she says: 'I have been thinking about this since the south road.' She does not elaborate. She does not need to.

A) 'So have I.' Two words. She holds your gaze for a long moment. Then she puts the knife down and turns toward you and the rest of the watch is not spent watching. (+ROMANCE OATH Sera, vivid fade to black) --> Scene 69

B) 'Tell me what you found in that village. The real version.' She tells you. It is terrible. You hold it together. Sometime before dawn the holding becomes something else. (+ROMANCE OATH Sera, emotional and physical, fade to black) --> Scene 69

C) 'I did not want to get to Vogler without saying something.' She considers this. Then: 'What are you saying?' You tell her. (+ROMANCE OATH Sera) --> Scene 69

SCENE 68C — THE LAST CAMP — VAEL

Forest Road — Night, Day 3 (if Vael Oath-track active)

CONDITIONAL SCENE

This scene occurs if Vael is at Flame level or above.

She is cleaning her equipment for the third time, which is how you know she is not actually thinking about her equipment. She looks up when you approach with the expression of someone who has made a decision and is not sure they have the nerve to act on it.

She says: 'I want to say something before tomorrow and I need you to let me finish it because I am going to say it badly.' She looks at her sword. 'I have been here six months and the only person whose opinion of me I actually care about is yours. I did not plan for that. I do not know what to do with it. But we are one day from Vogler and I am not going to be someone who did not say it.'

ROMANCE MOMENT

She is looking at you now. The firelight is behind you and her expression is completely unguarded — all the competitive competence and dry deflection set aside, just: a person who told you a true thing and is waiting to see what you do with it. She is slightly breathless. She would hate knowing that you can see that.

A) 'I know. I have known for a while. I did not know what to do with it either.' She exhales. Somewhere in that exhale is a laugh. Then she closes the distance and so do you. (+ROMANCE OATH Vael, passionate fade to black) --> Scene 69

B) 'You said it exactly right.' You mean this. She blinks. Then she sets down the sword and reaches for you. (+ROMANCE OATH Vael, vivid tender fade to black) --> Scene 69

C) Say nothing. Close the distance instead. She makes a small surprised sound and then she is kissing you back like she has been waiting to for weeks, which she has. (+ROMANCE OATH Vael) --> Scene 69

PALADIN SCENE P4 — THE CHOOSING

Forest Road — Dusk, Night Before Vogler

PALADIN ONLY — THE MOST IMPORTANT SCENE

Count your God Sign tallies now. The god with the most tallies has been reaching for you throughout this journey. Fighters: skip ahead to Scene 70.

You are on watch. The camp is quiet behind you. The road south is dark. Tomorrow you reach Vogler. The presence is here tonight. Not behind you — not anywhere you can point at. It is simply present, the way a colour is present when you open your eyes. You have felt it before. It has been patient. It is still patient. But tonight you understand, in the way you understand things below language, that it has brought you this far and will not push you further. Whatever comes next is your decision.

DIVINE SIGN

The forest is still. The stars are out — Solinari rising, Lunitari somewhere behind the clouds, and in the space between them, if you look in the right way, a darkness that is not empty: Nuitari, the Black Moon. All three moons moving through their courses. And below them, somewhere very far down, the presence. Patient. Waiting. Still not asking.

Count your tallies:

PALADINE	KIRI-JOLITH	MISHAKAL	HABBAKUK	BRANCHALA
Signs: ___	Signs: ___	Signs: ___	Signs: ___	Signs: ___

Now choose:

A) Speak to Paladine. 'I am yours, if you will have me. I will guard what is good. I will not look away.' --> Scene P4_Paladine

B) Speak to Kiri-Jolith. 'I will fight. I will not waste what you give me. The line will hold while I stand.' --> Scene P4_KiriJolith

C) Speak to Mishakal. 'I will heal. I will not choose who deserves it. I will be where the hurt is.' --> Scene P4_Mishakal

D) Speak to Habbakuk. 'I will protect what cannot protect itself. I will not ask permission first.' --> Scene P4_Habbakuk

E) Speak to Branchala. 'I will hold onto the possibility of beauty in the middle of this. I will not let the war take everything.' --> Scene P4_Branchala

F) Remain silent. 'I am not ready to name you. But I will not pretend you are not here either.' --> Scene P4_Unnamed

G) The tallies do not match how you feel. Choose the god who calls to you most regardless of the count. --> (Choose from A-F based on feeling)

P4_Paladine — PALADINE RESPONDS

Platinum Dragon, The Valiant Warrior, Father of Good

Something vast and silver acknowledges you. Not with words — with the feeling of a great weight settling, not on you but around you, as if the space you occupy has been noted and found to matter. The silence after is profound.

> *DRAGONLANCE CAMEO — AN OLD MAN WITH A POINTY HAT*
>
> There is an old man sitting on a tree root nearby. He was not there before. He has a long beard, a battered pointy hat, and the general air of someone who wandered in by mistake and is enjoying the view. He looks at you with kind, gold-flecked eyes. 'Ah,' he says. 'Good. Very good.' He sounds pleased in the way someone sounds pleased when a thing they have been hoping for finally happens. When you look back he is gone. Fizban is, depending on who you ask, a befuddled old wizard, a Hero of the Lance, or Paladine himself walking the world in mortal guise. These three things are not mutually exclusive.

Mechanics: Devotion Oath (recommended). Sacred Weapon grants your longsword +CHA to attacks. Channel Divinity: Turn the Unholy. +1 ROSE. Advantage on CHA saves for the remainder of this adventure.

In the Main Campaign: Paladine was worshipped as the highest of the gods of good. His chosen were judges and guardians. His divine spark in you is a candle against a coming darkness — and candles matter.

Proceed to Scene 70.

P4_KiriJolith — KIRI-JOLITH RESPONDS

The Bison of Heaven, God of Just War

Something strikes. That is the only word for it — not painful but percussive, like a hammer on an anvil very close to you. A sound and a sensation at once. Then silence. Then the smell of steel and something that might be blood but might be rain.

Mechanics: Vengeance Oath (recommended) or Devotion. Vow of Enmity: choose one enemy per fight to gain Advantage against for 1 minute. Abjure Enemy: one creature within 60 ft. must make WIS DC 13 save or be frightened and halved in speed for 1 minute. +2 SWORD.

In the Main Campaign: Kiri-Jolith has always chosen those who fight not for glory but for the person beside them. His paladins will find that fighting to give someone else a chance to live is its own kind of prayer.

Proceed to Scene 70.

P4_Mishakal — MISHAKAL RESPONDS

The Blue Lady, Goddess of Healing and Compassion

Warmth. Simple and enormous. Your hands feel it first — both palms, spreading up your arms and settling in your chest. It is the warmth of something that is pleased with you. Not proud. Pleased. Like coming home.

Mechanics: Devotion Oath. Sacred Weapon. Channel Divinity: Turn the Unholy. Bonus: Lay on Hands pool increases to 15 HP per long rest. Cure Wounds spell added to your spells known (no slot required, 1/day). +2 ROSE.

In the Main Campaign: Mishakal's return is the most significant spiritual event in Krynn's history since the Cataclysm. Her chosen carry actual divine healing in a world that has forgotten what that feels like. The healing you provide will be understood by NPCs as a miracle. Because it is.

Proceed to Scene 70.

P4_Habbakuk — HABBAKUK RESPONDS

The Fisher King, God of Nature, Sea, and Animal Life

The forest moves. Not like wind — like attention. The trees around you shift their weight fractionally. Somewhere close, an owl lands and watches you with complete stillness. A fox crosses the road twenty feet ahead and sits down and looks at you and then moves on.

Mechanics: Ancients Oath (recommended). Nature's Wrath: restrain one creature with spectral vines (STR/DEX DC 13, concentration 1 min). Turn the Faithless: fey and fiends within 30 ft. must make WIS DC 13 save or be turned for 1 min. +1 ROSE, +1 SWORD. Animals in the main campaign will not flee from you.

In the Main Campaign: Habbakuk is the god of living things that do not have a vote in what happens to their world. His paladins will find that Krynn's natural world responds to them — animals bring warnings, weather shifts, and occasionally something very old in a forest recognises you.

Proceed to Scene 70.

P4_Branchala — BRANCHALA RESPONDS

The Song of Life, God of Beauty, Art, and Inspiration

You hear music. Not in your ears — in the space behind your eyes. Something that is not quite a song and not quite a feeling and is exactly what you would call the reason not to give up. It lasts three seconds. It is enough.

Mechanics: Devotion or Ancients Oath. Channel Divinity: Sacred Weapon. Bonus: once per long rest, you may use your Channel Divinity to grant an ally advantage on their next ability check or attack roll. +2 ROSE.

In the Main Campaign: Branchala is the god of the unreasonable belief that beauty and hope survive. His paladins carry something the Dragon Army cannot easily destroy: the ability to make people feel, briefly, that it will be all right. This turns out to matter enormously.

Proceed to Scene 70.

P4_Unnamed — THE UNNAMED PRESENCE

The God Who Did Not Name Themselves

The presence acknowledges your silence the way a patient teacher acknowledges a student who says: I do not understand yet. Not disappointment. Something that is almost approval. The between-spaces are where most thinking actually happens.

Mechanics: Choose any Sacred Oath at Level 3. Bonus: once per long rest, you may roll twice on any Religion or History check and take the better result. +1 ROSE, +1 CROWN.

In the Main Campaign: The unnamed presence has been patient for three hundred years. Your god's identity will become clearer through your actions rather than through declaration. What you do in Vogler will matter more than what you said tonight.

Proceed to Scene 70.

SCENE DG4 — THE RECKONING

Vogler Road — The Day Before Vogler (Paladin Who Has Fallen)

> *FALLEN PALADINS ONLY*
> If you are HELD, HELD FIRM, PURIFIED, or PULLED BACK: skip to Scene 70.

You are on the last road before Vogler. The column has stopped for water. You are sitting on a stone wall looking at the lake in the distance when you hear footsteps approaching — not Aldric's, not Mira's. The figure is old. Very old. Robes that are neither white nor grey but the specific colour of very old wood. A face like a map of decisions made and paid for. He sits down without being invited and looks at the lake with you for a while.

DRAGONLANCE: ELISTAN OF PALANTHAS (or a messenger in his name)

Elistan was the first Chosen of Paladine after the Cataclysm — the first person in three hundred years to carry true divine power. He did not come to judge you. He came because someone asked him to find you.

'You've been carrying something that isn't yours,' he says. Not unkindly. Factually. 'It is not permanent. But it does not come off easily. The question is whether you want it off badly enough.' He looks at you. 'Not whether you are sorry. Whether you want to be different.' He waits.

This is the hardest question the prelude asks. Not 'did you fall' — you know the answer to that. But whether the falling was truly the end of something or whether it was a lesson you are willing to carry forward. The answer has to be real. He will know if it isn't.

A) Yes. I want to be different. I want to understand what I chose and unmake it. (Full recovery) --> Scene DG4_recover

B) I want to be different but I don't know if I can. That's the honest answer. (Partial recovery) --> Scene DG4_partial

C) I want redemption more than anything. But I don't have the path. (Ember path) --> Scene DG4_ember

D) I made a rational choice. I stand by it. (No recovery — remain fallen) --> Scene DG4_fallen

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SCENE DG4_recover — THE RETURN

Vogler Road — Recovery

He nods once. He puts his hand on your head for a moment — briefly, the way a blessing works when it is genuinely meant — and then he stands and walks away. The road is the same road. The lake is the same lake. Your hands feel clean. Not new-clean. Clean the way things are clean when they have been used and washed and used again. Your god's warmth is back in full, unfiltered, entirely present.

✦ *MAGIC ITEM GAINED: THE VOW RESTORED*

Wondrous Item (Requires Attunement by a Paladin), Uncommon

A small medallion of white-silver, shaped like a closed fist holding a flame.

Mechanics: Once per long rest: when you use Lay on Hands, you may also remove one condition: frightened, charmed, or poisoned. Advantage on saving throws against being charmed or possessed by fiends or undead.

Lore: Carried by one who fell and chose to return.

A) Proceed to Scene 70. --> Scene 70

SCENE DG4_partial — THE SCAR

Vogler Road — Partial Recovery

He does not argue with the honesty. 'That is a better answer than certainty,' he says. Your Lay on Hands is restored. The muffled quality in your prayers is mostly gone. But there is still a small thing — a faint violet note to the golden warmth.

MARK ON YOUR CHARACTER SHEET — FAULTY DIVINE POWERS

Lay on Hands: restored to full pool. Spell slots: each time you expend a spell slot, roll 1d6 first. On a 1 or 2, the slot is spent but the spell fails. This instability ends if you complete the Quest of the Returning Flame.

❖ *MAGIC ITEM GAINED: THE SHARD OF RETURNING LIGHT*

Wondrous Item (Requires Attunement by a Paladin), Uncommon — GROWING

A sliver of white crystal that throws no reflection and casts no shadow. It is slightly warm.

Mechanics: Advantage on saves against being frightened. Once per long rest, as a bonus action: creatures of your choice within 10 ft. that are frightened or charmed may reroll their saving throw with advantage. QUEST STATE: grows stronger when quest is completed.

Lore: Given to a paladin whose faith is cracked but not broken. The crystal holds light it hasn't earned yet, on credit.

QUEST: THE RETURNING FLAME

Complete in Shadow of the Dragon Queen: Find the Shrine of Mishakal (or any good-aligned god shrine). Spend a full night in honest prayer. In the same session, perform one act of genuine self-sacrifice for a stranger. When both conditions are met: faulty spell mechanic ends permanently. The Shard upgrades: bonus action also grants 2d6 temp HP. Once per long rest: cast Protection from Evil and Good without a slot.

A) Proceed to Scene 70. --> Scene 70

SCENE DG4_ember — THE EMBER

Vogler Road — The Wanting Without the Way

Elistan is quiet for a long time. 'That is the hardest state,' he says at last. 'Wanting and not having the path. It is not failure. It is the condition that precedes everything real.' He gives you something small and closes your fingers around it.

Your Lay on Hands pool is restored to half normal (rounded up). Your divine abilities still function — unevenly, with effort. But the wanting is a kind of fire, and fire is not nothing.

❖ *MAGIC ITEM GAINED: THE EMBER THAT REMAINED*

Wondrous Item (Requires Attunement by a Paladin), Uncommon — SEEKING

A small piece of charcoal that is faintly warm at the centre when you hold it in a closed fist.

Mechanics: Lay on Hands pool is half normal maximum (rounded up). Once per long rest: spend 10 minutes in honest prayer to cast Guidance on yourself without a slot. Each time you act in direct service of an innocent without personal benefit, mark one tally. At 5 tallies, the ember becomes The Vow Restored. Tallies reset if you knowingly act against innocents.

Lore: Given to a paladin who wanted the way back and didn't have it yet. The gods of good do not require certainty — they require the wanting.

A) Proceed to Scene 70. --> Scene 70

SCENE DG4_fallen — THE GIFT OF THE DARK QUEEN

Vogler Road — No Recovery

He looks at you for a long moment. 'You believe it,' he says. 'That is real.' He stands. He does not touch you. 'When you understand what you chose,' he says, 'the door is still open. It is always open. The gods of good do not lock doors.' He walks away. That night, something else leaves gifts at the edge of your bedroll. They are beautiful. They are cold.

❖ *MAGIC ITEM GAINED: THE QUEEN'S BRAND*

Wondrous Item (Requires Attunement), Uncommon — TAINTED

A black iron ring inlaid with five colours of enamel — red, blue, black, green, white — in the pattern of five dragon heads.

Mechanics: Lay on Hands heals normally. Once per long rest: add 1d6 necrotic damage to a melee attack. However: at dawn each day, DC 12 WIS save or take 1 point of Exhaustion. Removing the ring requires Remove Curse or Greater Restoration.

Lore: A gift from Takhisis to a paladin she considers an investment. The Queen of Darkness plays a long game.

❖ *MAGIC ITEM GAINED: THE UNASKED QUESTION*

Weapon (Longsword), Requires Attunement, Rare — TAINTED

A longsword with a blade of black steel that reflects nothing. The crossguard is five interlocking crescents.

Mechanics: +1 to attack and damage rolls. Once per long rest: on a hit, target makes DC 13 WIS save or is frightened until end of their next turn. Whenever you use this ability, make a DC 12 WIS save yourself or take 1 Exhaustion. The sword cannot be lost — if separated, it reappears in your pack within 24 hours.

Lore: A gift from Takhisis to a paladin she considers a long-term investment. It can be unmade only at the Shrine of Paladine by someone who genuinely no longer wants what it offers.

✦ MAGIC ITEM GAINED: THE SHADOW MANTLE

Wondrous Item (Cloak), Requires Attunement, Rare — TAINTED

A cloak of deep violet-black that absorbs the light around you slightly.

Mechanics: +1 to AC. Advantage on Stealth checks in dim light or darkness. Once per long rest: become heavily obscured to creatures more than 5 ft. away until start of your next turn. Disadvantage on Persuasion checks with clerics and paladins of good-aligned gods. Removing the cloak requires a DC 14 WIS save at dawn. On failure, you feel no desire to remove it.

Lore: Takhisis gives good gifts. That is the point.

YOUR PALADIN ABILITIES — THE SECRET PATRON

Until you formally pledge to Takhisis in Shadow of the Dragon Queen, your paladin abilities continue to function — but their source has changed. Lay on Hands heals normally. Divine Smite is very slightly violet. Spell slots function. You are, right now, a paladin of Takhisis who does not know it yet.

QUEST: THE PLEDGE OF THE FIVE HEADS

In Shadow of the Dragon Queen: Takhisis will reach for you at moments of violence, desperation, or victory. When ready, seek a Dragon Army officer of Black Wing Command who carries her symbol. The pledge is private, brief, and irreversible. Upon pledging: Oathbreaker subclass. Channel Divinity becomes Animate Dead and Aura of Hate. Lay on Hands can harm enemies. The redemption arc remains available. Elistan said the door is always open.

A) Proceed to Scene 70. --> Scene 70

SCENE M4 — THE VOGLER QUESTION

Vogler Road — Day Before the City (Fighter Only)

FIGHTER ONLY — MEASURE SUBPLOT CONCLUSION

Count your Measure Track score: 3-4 = Scholar, 5-7 = Practitioner, 8+ = Keeper. This determines your gift.

Ser Aldous finds you at the edge of the last camp. He has the old book again — the cracked binding one, not the official Measure. He sets it down beside you. 'One more question,' he says. 'Tomorrow you ride into Vogler. You will be a newly-oathed squire of the Knights of Solamnia carrying the Measure you have been learning for three weeks. Someone in that village will need you to know what it means. What do you know?'

A) 'I know the Measure is a tool for protecting people. Not a shield for the person holding it. If I have to choose between the law and the person, the law is there to serve the person.' (The Keeper's answer — highest track) --> Scene M4_keeper

B) 'I know the Measure requires me to make judgment calls I cannot undo. And that the right call is not always the comfortable one.' (The Practitioner's answer — middle track) --> Scene M4_practitioner

C) 'I know I do not know everything yet. But I know enough to hold the line until I do.' (The Scholar's answer — early track, honest) --> Scene M4_scholar

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SCENE M4_keeper — THE KEEPER'S GIFT

The Last Camp

He nods slowly. Not just at the answer — at the person saying it. 'That is what the Measure says,' he tells you. 'Not in those words. But that is what it says.' He hands you the old book. 'Not a copy. The original. My copy, the one I have carried for forty years. I do not need it anymore. I have it memorised.' He looks at you. 'You have what matters. Go use it.'

✦ *MAGIC ITEM GAINED: ALDOUS'S MEASURE*

Wondrous Item (Requires Attunement by a Solamnic Knight), Uncommon

A small, ancient book with a cracked leather binding and forty years of margin notes in Ser Aldous's precise hand. The pages are worn thin where he returned to them most. It smells of tallow and old stone — the chapel library at Brightholm.

Mechanics: While attuned: advantage on History checks related to law, justice, or the Knights of Solamnia. Once per long rest: you may consult the book to automatically know the Measure's position on any legal or ethical question (the DM will provide the answer). Additionally, Insight checks against NPCs who are acting under false pretence of law are made with advantage.

Lore: Ser Aldous of Brightholm carried this book through forty years of knighthood and gave it to the squire who understood it fastest. In the main campaign, senior Solamnic Knights will recognise it and understand what it means that you are carrying it.

A) Proceed to Scene 70. --> Scene 70

SCENE M4_practitioner — THE PRACTITIONER'S GIFT

The Last Camp

He is quiet for a moment. Then: 'That is honest. That is the honest answer and it is the right answer.' He reaches into his robe and takes out something he has been carrying. 'I was not sure I would give you this,' he says. 'But you have earned it. Not because you were perfect. Because you understood what you were not perfect at and kept going anyway.'

✦ *MAGIC ITEM GAINED: THE CHAPLAIN'S SEAL*

Wondrous Item (Requires Attunement), Uncommon

A brass stamp in the shape of the Solamnic sun, worn smooth with use. Aldous has used it to seal documents for thirty years. When you press it to paper, the impression is clean and permanent.

Mechanics: While attuned: once per long rest you may invoke the Measure's authority — any Intimidation or Persuasion check made to enforce law or protect innocents is made with advantage. Additionally, documents bearing this seal are treated as legally binding by any Solamnic NPC of Knight rank or below.

Lore: A working seal, not ceremonial. Aldous of Brightholm's seal carries forty years of genuine decisions. In the main campaign, NPCs who recognise it will understand that its bearer earned it.

A) Proceed to Scene 70. --> Scene 70

SCENE M4_scholar — THE SCHOLAR'S GIFT

The Last Camp

'That,' says Aldous, 'is the truest thing a new squire can know.' He looks at you for a moment. 'You will make mistakes in Vogler. Every new knight does. What matters is that you have the foundation to understand them.' He sets the old cracked book down in front of you. 'Read the third chapter tonight. Then read it again after Vogler. See how different it looks.'

✦ *MAGIC ITEM GAINED: THE COMMENTARIES (INCOMPLETE)*

Wondrous Item (Requires Attunement), Common — Grows in Power

A copy of the secondary Measure commentaries, heavily annotated by Ser Aldous but with wide margins left blank. He intended you to fill them.

Mechanics: While attuned: advantage on History checks about Solamnic law. After each completed adventure in which you faced a Measure dilemma, add a note to one blank page. When all blank pages are filled (DM discretion, usually 3-5 adventures), the book becomes Aldous's Measure (Uncommon, see Keeper's gift). The item grows with you.

Lore: A book given to someone at the beginning of understanding, not the end. The best version of this gift is earned later. In the main campaign, any Solamnic Knight who examines it will read Aldous's marginal note on the front page: 'For the squire who had the sense to know what they did not know yet.'

A) Proceed to Scene 70. --> Scene 70

SCENE 69 — MIRA AT THE CROSSROADS

Forest Road Junction — Afternoon, Day 3

The road splits. North to safety. South toward Vogler. Mira stands at the junction. 'I told myself I was going to take the safe road. I am not going to do that.'

A) South. She falls in beside you. (+2 ROSE, ROMANCE OATH Mira if Flame active) --> Scene 69B
B) 'North. Take the others to safety.' (Romance pauses until main campaign.) --> Scene 69B

SCENE 69B — THE LAKE AT DAWN

South Road — Day 3, Final Approach

The lake appears first as light — the reflection of the sunrise off water, a brightness on the southern horizon that is different from sky-brightness, flatter and wider and the colour of beaten silver. Then the water. Then the village.

Vogler in the early morning is beautiful. That is the thing no one warned you about — that the place you are riding to defend is genuinely, quietly, achingly beautiful. Stone buildings along the waterfront. Boats at the pier. Smoke from morning cooking fires. A stand of aspens at the east end that have gone gold with autumn and are catching the sunrise in a way that looks like the trees are on fire in the good way.

Aldric rides beside you. He sees the lake and for a moment his face does something it almost never does: it opens. Then it reassembles. But you saw it.

> ***IF MIRA IS WITH YOU:*** *She stops her horse. 'My mother's village looked like this.' Very quiet. Then she rides on.*
>
> ***IF TARIEL IS WITH YOU:*** *Her notebook stays closed. This is not an observation she is willing to reduce to writing.*
>
> ***IF LYSANDER IS WITH YOU:*** *He is standing at the ridgeline, separate from the column, looking at the lake. He looks exactly like a Knight of the Sword on the morning of a battle, which is what he is whether the paperwork agrees or not.*

A) Stop. Look. Remember this. (+1 ROSE) --> Scene 70
B) 'It is worth saving.' (+1 ROSE, +1 SWORD) --> Scene 70
C) Ride on. The beauty does not change the numbers. (+1 SWORD, +1 CROWN) --> Scene 70

SCENE 70 — THE BRIDGE

South Road — Vogler Approach, Late Day 3

The lake appears first. Then the village. And on the bridge into Vogler: a Dragon Army forward element setting up a checkpoint. Four soldiers. They have not seen you yet.

ROLL REQUIRED: Perception (+2) | WIS | DC 14
SUCCESS (roll 14+): Two days to Vogler, not three. You warn the group. The party gains surprise.
FAILURE (roll 1-13): No surprise — initiative is rolled normally.

COMBAT ENCOUNTER — THE BRIDGE CHECKPOINT
ENEMIES:
• Human Soldier x4: AC 14, HP 16 each. Longsword +4 1d8+2.
• Sergeant (one of the four): HP 22. Bonus action Shout: one ally rerolls a failed attack.
Rewards: 30 XP. Bridge clear. The people of Vogler watched the fight from the walls.
Fallen (0 HP): Aldric holds the sergeant. You enter Vogler at 1 HP. Villagers treat your wounds.

A) Proceed to Scene 71. --> Scene 71

SCENE 71 — THE FIRST SIGHT OF VOGLER

Vogler — Evening

Vogler in the late afternoon has the quality of a place that has been bracing itself and is briefly, exhaustedly, relieved. The people watching from the walls as you crossed the bridge have the faces of people for whom Solamnic armour is the best thing they have seen this week.

Behind you, the Dragon Army is moving. Behind you, also, are weeks that changed the shape of what you are. You are a squire now — sworn, blooded, tired in the specific way of someone who has been tested at intervals and kept passing.

Whatever comes next is the main campaign. This was how it began.

Your Prelude Ends Here
Turn to the Order Outcome section for your squiring ceremony and title. Then turn to the Romance Epilogue section. Then turn to THE BRIDGE TO THE CAMPAIGN.

ORDER OUTCOMES — SQUIRE OF YOUR ORDER

SQUIRE OF THE ROSE

Motto: Est Sularus oth Mithas — My honour is my life.

You earned this not through outstanding sword work but through asking the right questions and standing by the answers. The Rose values wisdom and moral courage. Ser Aldous was present at your oath. He did not try to hide that he was moved.

> *Squire Title Granted*
> Squire-Scholar of the Rose. Addressed as 'Squire', given deference in matters of law and the Measure.

> *Fighter Ability (carry into main campaign)*
> Historical Insight (1/day): Ask the DM one true lore question. Advantage on Persuasion checks when appealing to someone's sense of justice.

> *Paladin Ability (carry into main campaign)*
> Voice of Mercy (1/day): When you use Lay on Hands on a creature, they are also freed of one condition (frightened, charmed, or poisoned). Advantage on Persuasion with any NPC who has seen you act against personal interest to protect someone.

Your Road to Vogler:

You ride into Vogler carrying the weight of what justice means when law fails it. Start with +2 Persuasion and the trait: Voice of the Rose (NPCs who see you protect someone at personal cost trust you immediately).

SQUIRE OF THE SWORD

Motto: The blade that does not waver.

You earned this on the south road, on the ridge, at the bridge — in every fight where you chose to stand rather than step back. Aldric was in the front row at your oath. You saw him.

> *Squire Title Granted*
> Squire-Warrior of the Sword. Addressed as 'Squire', first position in any fighting formation.

Fighter Ability (carry into main campaign)

Combat Resolve (1/day): When reduced to 0 HP, make one final attack before falling. When you succeed on a death save, use Second Wind as a reaction.

Paladin Ability (carry into main campaign)

Righteous Fury (1/day): When you use Divine Smite, you may choose to double the radiant damage. The first time in each combat that an ally is reduced to 0 HP within 30 ft. of you, your next attack before the end of your next turn has Advantage.

Your Road to Vogler:

You ride into Vogler knowing what is coming will need everything you have. Start with +2 Athletics and the trait: Blade-Oath (advantage on first attack of any combat).

SQUIRE OF THE CROWN

Motto: Law is the shield of the innocent.

You kept the law when others would have broken it and understood that duty is the structure that lets conscience act in the world. Lord Caeron conducted your squiring ceremony himself. Afterwards, in private, he shook your hand instead of saluting. That is not in the protocol.

Squire Title Granted

Squire-Commander of the Crown (junior). Given deference in command decisions.

Fighter Ability (carry into main campaign)

Authority of the Crown (1/day): Issue a command to a non-hostile NPC. They comply unless it directly harms them. Advantage on Intimidation checks against Dragon Army soldiers.

Paladin Ability (carry into main campaign)

Aura of Command (passive): Your Aura of Protection (CHA +2 to saves) also applies to allies' attack rolls against enemies that are frightened, stunned, or prone. Authority of the Crown (1/day): same as Fighter version.

Your Road to Vogler:

You ride into Vogler as the Order's standard. People will look to you when things fall apart. Start with +2 Persuasion/Intimidation and the trait: Command Presence (NPCs do not panic in your presence during combat).

ROMANCE EPILOGUES — OATH ENDINGS

SCENE 72 — ALDRIC VOSS

He finds you after the squiring when everyone else has gone. 'I spent eight months being competitive with you. I think that was because I did not know what else to do with it.' He looks at you. 'I know now.' He says I love you with staying — with showing up — with the way his hand finds yours. In the main campaign, Aldric Voss is a named companion with his own quest line.

SCENE 73 — THESSALY BRIGHTWATER

She interviews you one last time. Except this time: 'What do you want people to remember about what happened here?' She writes it down carefully. Then she closes the notebook. Sets it on the wall. Looks at you without the professional distance. 'I stopped being a journalist about you a while ago.' She puts it down. In the main campaign, Thessaly provides intelligence and covers you.

SCENE 74 — COMMANDER SERATH

They find you just before dawn. 'I am trying to become the kind of person who deserves it. I have not succeeded yet. But I am trying. I have not been trying for anyone before.' In the main campaign, Serath is a morally complex ally.

SCENE 75 — MIRA OF THE OAKS

She walks beside you on the last road. She does not touch you, and she does not need to. At some point she says, very quietly: 'I was not looking for this.' You were not either. In the main campaign, Mira is the party's healer and the person you fight hardest to keep standing.

SCENE 76 — LORD CAERON ASHVALE

He gives you your evaluation report. In the Overall Assessment box he has written: 'This squire will be remarkable. I have no further notes.' He stops at the door. 'The Order of the Crown values constancy. I intend to be constant.' In the main campaign, Caeron provides strategic resources and a quest line about what he is hiding.

SCENE 77 — SERA NIGHTHOLLOW

She is already awake and has scouted the perimeter. She says: 'I should tell you that I am not easy to be with. I have been told this.' You tell her you are not particularly easy either. Then, not smiling but with the thing behind her eyes that is equivalent: 'All right.' That is everything. In the main campaign, Sera Nighthollow is a scout companion with her own quest line.

SCENE 78 — VAEL ASHMORE

She does not do the thing where people are strange in the morning after something real. She is exactly herself — a little softer. She hands you your gear and says: 'For what it is worth, I have no regrets.' Then you are both laughing. 'I want to do this again. After. When there is an after.' In the main campaign, Vael Ashmore is a Crown-path companion with her own quest line.

SCENE 79 — TARIEL DUSKMANTLE

She does not take the Oath. She watches you take it from the back of the chapel with her notebook open and her pen still. She writes one line. Afterward: 'I have decided to stay. Not as an observer.' She takes the credential and folds it and puts it in your hand. 'I do not need this anymore. I know what I am observing.' In the main campaign, Tariel Duskmantle is a political advisor with no rank, no oath, and the most accurate assessment of power in any room she enters. She loves you the way she loves an argument: completely, with her full attention, and with the knowledge that the conclusion may change.

SCENE 80 — LYSANDER GRAVES

He is not at the ceremony. He is at the gate, already mounted, facing south. On the road he does not ride beside you — he rides near. The night before Vogler: 'I will be at the wall. Whatever they need me to be. Sword for hire. No title, no Oath, no complications.' He looks at you. 'Except one.' In the main campaign, Lysander Graves is an unaffiliated fighter with no rank and the best sword arm in Vogler. He is the most dangerous kind of complication: a good man without a system, in love with someone inside one.

THE BRIDGE TO THE CAMPAIGN

What You Carry Forward	Details
Your Class	Fighter or Paladin. Both Level 3. Bring your full character sheet.
Your Order	Determines social standing with Solamnic NPCs and Caeron's attitude.
Sacred Oath / Archetype	Paladin: god and Oath active. Fighter: Archetype features active.
Active Companions	Any companion at Flame or Oath level joins the main campaign party.
Romance Status	Oath-level romances have dedicated scenes in Chapters 1-3.
Serath (if kept)	Dragon Army intelligence at key points — but creates political tension.
Refugees saved	May reappear in Vogler or Kalaman with information or aid.
The Dispatch Pouch	If kept: Caeron can use it to delay the Dragon Army by six hours.
Paladin: God Relationship	Your deity is active. Divine signs continue.
Corruption Track 1	STEADFAST through FALLEN. Affects institution-related checks.
Corruption Track 2	STEADFAST through FALLEN. Affects institution-related checks.
The Hollow Crown (if active)	Disadvantage on Order authority Persuasion. FALLEN: also Advantage on individual appeals.
The Broken Sword (if active)	Disadvantage on institutional defence Persuasion. FALLEN: also Advantage on civilian defence attacks.
Diplomatic Observer (if staying)	Political advisor, intelligence asset, no rank.
Disgraced Knight (if riding to Vogler)	Unaffiliated fighter. Best sword arm available.
Combat XP	Total your XP. 5 fights available. 120 XP max.

SCORE SHEET — TALLY EVERYTHING HERE

CLASS: Fighter / Paladin (circle)

ORDER POINTS: ROSE: ___ pts | SWORD: ___ pts | CROWN: ___ pts Highest score = Your Order. Tiebreaker: choose the one that feels true.

PALADIN — GOD SIGN TALLIES:

PALADINE: ___ | KIRI-JOLITH: ___ | MISHAKAL: ___ | HABBAKUK: ___ | BRANCHALA: ___ God chosen at Scene P4: _____ Sacred Oath: Devotion / Ancients / Vengeance (circle)

FIGHTER — ARCHETYPE: Champion / Battle Master / Eldritch Knight (circle)

COMPANIONS AT ADVENTURE'S END (circle):

Aldric / Thessaly / Serath / Mira / Caeron / Sera / Vael / Tariel / Lysander

ROMANCE OATH REACHED WITH (circle):

Aldric / Thessaly / Serath / Mira / Caeron / Sera / Vael / Tariel / Lysander / None

CORRUPTION TRACKS:

CORRUPTION TRACK 1: STEADFAST / QUESTIONING / SHAKEN / CONVINCED / FALLEN / NOT ENGAGED ROMANCE TRACK (same companion): NONE / SPARK / FLAME / OATH

CORRUPTION TRACK 2: STEADFAST / QUESTIONING / SHAKEN / CONVINCED / FALLEN / NOT ENGAGED ROMANCE TRACK (same companion): NONE / SPARK / FLAME / OATH

ACTIVE MODIFIERS:

THE HOLLOW CROWN: Reduced / Full / Not Active THE BROKEN SWORD: Reduced / Full / Not Active

DISPATCH POUCH KEPT: Yes / No **TOTAL XP EARNED:** ___ / 120

Paladin Dark God Track:

DG Track: HELD FIRM / HELD / LISTENING / COMPROMISED / FALLEN / DEEPLY FALLEN / PURIFIED / RETURNED / SCARRED

Fighter Measure Track:

Scene	Points	Running Total
M1		
M2		
M3		
M4		Final: Scholar / Practitioner / Keeper

CORRUPTION MODIFIER REFERENCE

THE HOLLOW CROWN

CONVINCED (reduced): Disadvantage on Persuasion when invoking Order authority. Fixable through main campaign story.

FALLEN (full): Disadvantage on Order authority Persuasion. Advantage on individual appeals. Permanent unless resolved through main campaign quest.

THE BROKEN SWORD

CONVINCED (reduced): Disadvantage on Persuasion when defending institutional decisions. Fixable through story.

FALLEN (full): Disadvantage on institutional defence Persuasion. Advantage on civilian defence attack rolls. Permanent unless resolved through quest.

INTERACTIONS

Both FALLEN: Both modifiers full strength. Hardest character — sees both sides of every argument.

SHAKEN+ corruption + LISTENING+ DG: All DG saves at Disadvantage.

FALLEN corruption + FALLEN DG: Darkest Paladin outcome. Recovery requires two separate quests.

STEADFAST corruption + HELD FIRM DG: Strongest character. Advantage on charm/compulsion/fear saves for remainder of prelude and first chapter of main campaign.

FALLEN corruption + Keeper Measure (Fighter): Most sophisticated fall. You understand the Measure deeply AND believe it is insufficient. Aldous will recognise this.

Your oath is spoken. Your blade is blooded. The road to Vogler is open.

The Dragon Queen's armies are marching.

The gods are waking.

Ride on, Squire.

End of The Knight's Oath — Version 19